

PHEONIX RISING

LIBERATE YOURSELF FROM THE SHADOWS
AN EMBRACE TRUE FREEDOM:



CLEAN SLATE

BREAKTHROUGH EXPERIENCE

Understand Yourself
Transform Your Past. Rebuild Your
Power. & Reinvent Yourself

SHAE MATTHEWS

INNER GAME COACHING FOR RAPID TRANSFORMATION

MAY ALL YOUR EXPERIENCES BRING YOU HIGHER WISDOM

***Dedicated To Lois Rossi My Brother On The Path. Co Originator and Co
Trainer of the clean slate process.***

***For all the hours of transformation and deep dive research and application
of life experience that has been brought to this work. Thanks for all
the support and dedication to the service of human transformation.***

May all beings be blessed with physical, emotional and spiritual health.



Preface

This piece of writing is part information and part a direct conversation between you and I. Many who have read it, have said its one of the most important pieces of writing they have ever read — so I implore you to finish reading the whole ebook. Honest communication between 2 people leads to personality transformation, so I'm asking you to be honest with yourself as you read on. This piece is a combination of research and viewpoints I have on the subject which stem from working with clients (especially from understanding their lives before and after the work).

Essentially, I aim to give you the language and understanding of the unconscious patterns and processes which make you feel what you feel - especially the limitations you feel/have to creating the life you want and are capable of living. With what you are about to read, please note, that there are ways to change all of this for the better. There is hope, because:

"The paradox of trauma is that it has both the power to destroy and the power to transform and resurrect" - Peter A. Levine, Psychologist

I've also included a detailed case study plus real testimonials at the end. Words that are underlined link to the resources and research used in supporting my statements, so you can, if you choose, explore these ideas in depth. I invite you to do your own research on what's covered in what you are about to read.

I thank you for allowing me to have this conversation with you, as helping people radically transform their lives is my gift, passion and life's work.

Introduction

“Time heals all wounds”. How many times have you heard this reassuring phrase meaning that any painful and difficult situation won’t seem as bad as time passes?

In some cases, that’s exactly what will happen. As the years pass, painful memories fade from childhood issues/traumas/wounding fades, and we end up wondering why it all felt so overwhelming at the time. But, even though the painful ‘sting’ has gone, many won’t recognise the effect the schemas, trauma and wounding has on their present thoughts, actions and emotions, and how it will continue to affect them into the future. For a lot of people, the change will feel natural. **They accept it without any thought or action directed towards how to truly heal and be free of these effects, and instead, *just* cope with them.**

However, for some people, the passage of time can have the opposite effect. With trauma and wounding, the pain grows, gets worse, and can even develop into Post Traumatic Stress Disorder (PTSD). If you’ve had a hard experience in your past where something negative happened, or where you failed miserably, you may never step far outside your comfort zone again— forming self-limiting beliefs, settling for coping instead of healing, and being truly ‘free’. In that case, you’ve become incredibly limited because of your past—**Your emotions own you, rather than you owning your emotions.**

When this happens, your personality stops developing, and your life becomes quite repetitive.

You may continue to develop mentally and cognitively, such as learning from books and from higher education. You could have a head full of facts and knowledge, which are easily acquired as you read this eBook for example. But emotionally, you are stunted. If we never heal the past pain that effects us now and into the future, then we are forever crippled in our lives in many ways. As a result, we begin avoiding situations that would make us vulnerable to experiencing similar pain again. We become “frozen” in our development as a human being, unable to embrace and fully take-in new experiences while facing future challenges with ease.

Why is that? What’s going on?

First, let’s explore what trauma, wounding and Schemas actually are, how they work, how they affect your reality and future. They are big subjects and there are entire books, academic disciplines and research dedicated to them. That being said, I will do my best to distill what I know and how it all interrelates based on my own research and experience working with clients, saving you the time of exploring it all piece by piece.

What is Trauma?

The recognition of psychological trauma is a recent development. It was not until after the Vietnam War, when the evidence for the mental consequences on veterans was overwhelming, that PTSD was accepted as a mental disfunction, included in the Diagnostic and Statistical Manual of Mental Disorders (DSM) as a disorder.

There are amazing advocates and researchers coming up with new findings of trauma every day. At this point, the significance of trauma is undeniable, but there is still a long way until we fully comprehend all its ramifications and consequences.

Let's start by differentiating the several ways the word trauma is

used. The word trauma appears in many different publications

defining:

- an event,
- an experience,
- a reaction,
- a response
- a mental disorder.

Trauma as an event

Traumatic events are those that make people feel threatened, anxious, or frightened because its potential to cause physical, emotional, spiritual, or psychological harm. Examples: rape, bullying, oppression, racism, emotional abuse, emotional neglect, car accidents, surgery, natural disasters, foster care, entrapment, betrayal, poverty, etc.

Trauma as an experience

Any event could end up causing trauma if the reaction to it exceeds the capacity of the person to stay regulated.

How someone experiences the event is what will determine if it's traumatising or not. A traumatic experience depends on your perception of risk and is very individual. For a baby, being wet, cold, or hungry for "too" long can seem life-threatening. For an adolescent, failing an their schooling or being expelled from the team can seem life-threatening; for a mother with children breaking up from a romantic relationship can seem the end of the world.

Trauma as a reaction

Our innate survival mechanisms trigger a series of reactions with the sole purpose of keeping our system running. The best known is the fight-flight response, and many people call this reaction trauma.

Fight-flight is only one of the reactions triggered by a traumatic event that can end up traumatising the system, but there are several others: **Orienting, Attentive immobility, Social-engagement, Freeze, Tonic Immobility, Collapse Immobility, and Quiescent Immobility**. Google these if you are interested to learn more.

Trauma as a response

When danger is perceived, fear triggers a series of mechanisms that act without our desire for them to do so, generating all sorts of changes in ordinary functioning because the brain interprets fear as an indication that there is the possibility of “not making it” - not only staying alive but also maintaining one’s health, social position, family, jobs, freedom, autonomy, stability, etc.

The obvious response to such an impact in our system is to feel overwhelmed. Under the trauma lens, being overwhelmed means that we experience many emotions at the same time, or a few of them in an extremely intense way. That response takes us out of the “Window of Tolerance” which means that we lose control over our behaviour, thoughts, reactions, etc. This level of reactivity is called ‘dysregulation’ and will keep the cascade of changes in the system to continue in charge. If we don’t regain control over our response, we will probably stay traumatised. But if we deactivate the survival mechanisms by activating the executive functions of our brain, we would have really won the battle. The response by itself, even if never becomes trauma, may present symptoms that may leave marks and interfere with living our best lives.

The response to a shocking event will keep very vivid memories with some emotional charge, and may leave you hyper-vigilant for a while. But most of the effect of the response will fade away on themselves. Still, few symptoms could stay as a consequence of the response of the nervous system; many people call this PTSD as in post-traumatic stress. Some of them may sound almost identical as the ones on PTSD but the difference is that PTSD will not be as debilitating and they will be winding down as days pass.

Example: Hyper-activation, hypo-activation, dissociation, flashbacks, alertness, restlessness, etc.

Trauma as a mental disorder

PTSD/Complex-PTSD (more on this later) Developmental trauma, Attachment trauma, Intergenerational trauma, are some of the most common terms used to describe the mental disorder.

The difference between a reaction and a disorder is worth expanding. The way we react to danger has been in our systems since before we were humans. These reactions assume a danger that fortunately, we don't have to endure anymore. Still, we are wired to react as preys and consider anyone that attacks us, as a predator. That of course, assuming that we have not evolved at all. But we have, and besides the primitive responses of our autonomic nervous system (ANS), we count on with a very developed neocortex (prefrontal cortex specifically) that gives us the capacity to control the primitive responses. Not everyone that suffers a traumatic event, develops a mental disorder. We may go through traumatising, but we may not develop trauma. Here is the difference between both:

Traumatisation

This is the process that your system goes into after perceiving danger. The cascade of reactions makes changes in your functioning to keep the body alive. That process is really tolling to the system and can leave complications in your memory, perception, physiology,

etc.

Traumatisation can end when the danger is gone, or can continue after, depending on how your mind deals with the event. If you are still scared even when the situation turned in your favour and you are safe, the traumatising will continue.

Traumatisation can end up as a mental disorder, but not always. It can dissipate in hours, days, or weeks if you are safe and feel safe. Once your cortex sends the signal to the amygdala that the risk is over, the body will naturally try to go back to normal. The brain prefers equilibrium over chaos. According to the bible of psychiatry (DSM), if symptoms last for longer than 1 month, the diagnosis of PTSD can apply.

PTSD

PTSD is a set of alarm responses that occur when a survivor's nervous system remains on high alert after trauma in order to protect against further harm. The survivor's alert systems respond to reminders of the traumatic memories threat. Often additional triggers are added to a growing list of stressors. A person needs to have had direct (or been a witness to) events such as: life-threatening violence or death, severe bodily harm, serious accidents, physical or sexual assault, abuse (including childhood or domestic abuse), serious health problems, such as being admitted to intensive care and childbirth experiences, such as losing a baby etc. Or the person could be exposed after the fact such as military people who identify remains or first responders. This also includes Complex PTSD in which a person is subjected to repeated trauma, such as in the case of repeated child abuse, long term child or elderly neglect, repeated sexual abuse, being held in captivity, etc.

With all that said, PTSD can also happen from events that, on paper, don't seem 'intense'.

People with PTSD often experience feelings of panic or extreme fear, similar to the fear they felt during the traumatic event. A person with PTSD experiences four main types of difficulties:

Re-living the traumatic event – The person relives the event through unwanted and recurring memories, often in the form of vivid images and nightmares. There may be intense emotional or physical reactions, such as sweating, heart palpitations or panic when reminded of the event.

Being overly alert or wound up – The person experiences sleeping difficulties, irritability and lack of concentration, becoming easily startled and constantly on the lookout for signs of danger.

Avoiding reminders of the event – The person deliberately avoids activities, places, people, thoughts or feelings associated with the event because they bring back painful memories.

Feeling emotionally numb – The person loses interest in day-to-day activities, feels cut off and detached from friends and family, or feels emotionally flat and numb.

It's not unusual for people with PTSD to experience other mental health problems at the same time. These may have developed directly in response to the traumatic event or have

followed the PTSD. These additional problems, most commonly depression, anxiety and alcohol or drug use, are more likely to occur if PTSD has persisted for a long time.

According to **research**, 60 percent of men and 51 percent of women experience at least one potentially traumatic event in their lifetime. However, the lifetime prevalence of PTSD is significantly higher in women than in men. Some 84 percent of those suffering from PTSD may also exhibit various co-occurring diseases or disorders. It is important to note that a person with PTSD is at higher risk for suicide and intentional self-harm.

Wounding and psychological trauma can be caused by:

One-time events, such as an accident, sexual assault, injury, or a violent attack, *especially* if it was unexpected or happened in childhood.

Ongoing, relentless stress, such as living in a crime-ridden neighborhood, battling a life-threatening illness or experiencing traumatic events that occur repeatedly, such as bullying, sexual abuse (within an intimate relationship and/or childhood), domestic violence, or childhood neglect. This usually gives rise to C-PTSD.

Commonly overlooked causes, such as surgery (especially in the first 3 years of life), the sudden death of someone close, the breakup of a significant relationship, or a humiliating or deeply disappointing experience, especially if someone was deliberately cruel.

Coping with the trauma of a natural or manmade disaster can present unique challenges—even if you weren't directly involved in the event. In fact, while it's highly unlikely any of us will ever be the direct victims of a terrorist attack, plane crash, or mass shooting, we're all regularly bombarded by horrific images on social media and news sources of those people who have been. Viewing these distressing images over and over can overwhelm your nervous system and create traumatic stress.

Childhood Trauma and The Risk of Future Trauma

While traumatic events can happen to anyone, you're more likely to be traumatized by an event if you're already under a heavy stress load, have recently suffered a series of losses, or have been traumatized before—especially if the earlier trauma occurred in childhood.

Childhood trauma can result from anything that disrupts a child's sense of safety, including:

- An unstable or unsafe environment
- Separation from a parent
- Serious illness
- Intrusive medical procedures
- Sexual, physical, or verbal abuse
- Domestic violence
- Neglect
- Bullying from peers at school or abuse by teachers, etc.

Experiencing trauma in childhood can result in a severe and long-lasting effect. When childhood trauma is not resolved, a sense of fear and helplessness carries over into adulthood, setting the stage for further trauma. However, even if your trauma happened many years ago, there are healing steps you can take to overcome and heal the pain, learn to trust and connect to others again, and regain your sense of emotional balance.

Symptoms of Psychological Trauma and Wounding

We all react to trauma in different ways, experiencing a wide range of physical and emotional reactions. **Your responses are NORMAL reactions to ABNORMAL events.**

Some emotional & psychological symptoms:

- Shock, denial, or disbelief
- Confusion, difficulty concentrating
- Anger, irritability, mood swings
- Anxiety and fear
- Guilt, shame, self-blame
- Social — withdrawing from others (friends, family, lovers/relationships)
- Feeling sad or hopeless, depression
- Disassociation
- Feeling disconnected or numb
- Intrusive thoughts
- Comfort eating
- Phobias
- Self-Harming (cutting, drug abuse, alcoholism and other forms of escapism)
- Pessimistic about the future

Some physical symptoms:

- Insomnia, nightmares or night terrors
- Fatigue/low mood
- Being startled easily
- Difficulty concentrating
- Racing heartbeat
- Edginess and agitation
- Aches and pains
- Muscle tension

Trauma Overview

Traumatic experiences often involve a threat to life or safety, but any situation that leaves you feeling overwhelmed and isolated can result in trauma, even if it doesn't involve physical harm. The more frightened, helpless and emotionally scarred you feel, the more likely you are to be traumatised or wounded.

Suffering from trauma assumes that the disorder has developed fully and it has become somewhat "permanent." All the changes suffered during the traumatisation have left

symptoms and the system now functions in a dysregulated way on a regular basis. It will not disappear by itself; it will need interventions in order to heal and for you to thrive again.

The most significant changes are:

- Loss of homeostasis
- Dysregulated nervous system: tendency to stay hyper-activated, hypo=activated, or having both sympathetic and parasympathetic in override
- Loss of tolerance to affect; easily overwhelmed and overreactive.

I like to work with two notions of trauma — Trauma with a "Big T" (as outlined above) and trauma with a "little t" aka 'Wounding'. 'Little t' trauma isn't so well known and thought about. It's worth a deep dive to understand it.

'Little t' Trauma aka Wounding

Wounds stem from a negative experience (or set of experiences that may or may not have a direct, classical cause, such as a car accident) that causes pain on a deep psychological and emotional level. I still consider them a 'trauma' as such; they just have a different cause to classical trauma and a different expression.

When we feel into them, the lasting hurt and emotional responses often involves someone close: a family member, lover, mentor, friend, or other trusted individual.

Wounds may be tied to a specific event, arise upon learning a difficult truth about the world, or result from a physical limitation, condition, or challenge. **They can serve as the basis of self-limiting beliefs that restrict us and conflict our values.**

Often there are core emotions arising from wounds that we have at some point buried away. Emotions that we have decided not to feel and process and may form part of our identity. These emotions become wounds and hurt when we are reminded of them.

Emotional wounds become complicated when patterns of behaviour keep them, and us, protected. This is how they become entrenched deep within us. For example, after a series of bad breakups you might exclaim "All men (or women) are bastards (or bitches)!".

Another example of wounding or schema (more detail on Schema below) is not receiving a parent's love when someone failed to meet their unrealistic expectations, and resentment sets in. This may lead someone to stop talking about their goals, or even worse, refusal to try at all in the future because they believe they would only fail.

In both examples, the wounding is speaking, and directing the course for future relationships (or lack of), emotions, actions and belief systems. The focus of the wounds becomes smaller and smaller and easily proven. This unconscious course towards hurt becomes more and more certain.

Whatever they arose from, most traumatic and wounding experiences happen unexpectedly, meaning, people have little or no time to raise their emotional defences. The resulting pain is brutal and immediate. The fallout of this has lasting repercussions that will change people in significant and often negative ways. We may experience many different

painful events over a lifetime, including ones in our formative years. Emotional trauma and wounds feel like they are somewhat difficult (but not impossible) to move past, or to be dispelled, but often create a domino effect for other hurts that follow. **It's not the**

objective circumstances that determine whether an event is traumatic, but your subjective

emotional experience of the event. The reason why lingering subjective emotional experiences live on within us and cause persisting issues may have to do with the way memories of the traumatic/wounding events have been stored in our brains.

Traumatic and Wounding Memories are Stored Differently

According to neuroscience, the **brain stores traumatic memories** not just in one place but in multiple locations, and the same mechanisms are also involved with wounding and Schemas. This makes traumatic memories and wounding multidimensional, more destructive, and feel more difficult to process and resolve.

Furthermore, due to a phenomenon called **traumatic memory distortion**, people tend to remember experiencing even more trauma and wounding than they actually did. As a result, their over-remembered trauma can 'grow' and with time, they may experience increasing severity of PTSD symptoms, while the wounding and resulting beliefs systems deepen.

What's going on in a traumatised brain that is different to a non-traumatised brain?

A Deeper Exploration of the 3 Areas That Store Trauma and Wounding

There are 3 important parts that play a role in the traumatised brain and traumatised brains look different to non-traumatised brains in three predictable ways:

- The prefrontal cortex (PFC) - The Thinking Centre is under-activated,
- The anterior cingulate cortex (ACC) - The Emotion Regulation Centre is under- activated.
- The amygdala - The Fear Centre is over-activated.

- **The PFC, or thinking centre**, is located near the top of your head, behind your forehead. It's responsible for abilities including rational thought, problem-solving, personality, planning, empathy, and awareness of ourselves and others. When this area of the brain is strong, we are able to think clearly, make good decisions, and be aware of ourselves and others.
- **The ACC, or emotion regulation centre**, is located next to the prefrontal cortex, but is deeper inside the brain. This area is responsible (in part) for regulating emotion, and (ideally) has a close working relationship with the thinking centre. When this region is strong, we are able to manage difficult thoughts and emotions without being totally overwhelmed by them. While we might want to send a snarky email to a coworker, the emotion regulation centre reminds us that this is not a good idea, and helps us manage our emotions so that we don't do things we regret.
- Finally, **the amygdala**, a tiny structure deep inside our brain, serves as its fear centre. **This structure is outside of our conscious awareness or control, and its primary job is to receive all incoming information: everything you see, hear, touch, smell, and taste—and answer one question: “Is this a threat?”** If it detects that a dangerous threat is present, it produces fear in us. When this area is activated, we feel afraid, reactive, and vigilant. Research has shown that during traumatic events, the amygdala, also contributes to the formation of denser-than-normal memories and the perception of time slowing down. This causes the memories to be imprinted in greater detail in our memory, emotions, consciousness, and subconscious.

What these activations indicate is that a traumatised brain is ‘bottom-heavy,’ meaning that activations of lower, more primitive areas (including the fear centre) are high, while higher areas of the brain (also known as cortical areas) are under-activated. In other words, if you are traumatised, you may experience chronic stress, vigilance, fear, anxiety and irritation. You may also have a hard time feeling safe, calming down, or sleeping. These symptoms are all the result of a hyperactive amygdala.

At the same time, individuals who are traumatised may notice difficulties with concentration and attention, and often report they can't think clearly. Unsurprisingly, this is due to the thinking centre being under-activated.

Finally, sufferers of trauma will sometimes complain that they feel incapable of managing their emotions. For example, if someone spooks them, they may experience a rapid heart rate long after the joke is up, or may have a hard time ‘just letting go’ of minor annoyances. Even when they want to calm down and feel better, they just can't. This is in large part due to a weakened emotion regulation center.

‘Time Heals All Wounds’ and ‘I’m Working On Myself’

Getting back to the “Time heals all wounds” saying. The findings of the **World Mental Health Surveys** show that, in reality, only a minority of PTSD cases go into remission within months after onset. Unfortunately, the majority of PTSD sufferers experience symptoms for many years, and some, do not let up at all without proper treatment.

I believe that with emotional wounding, classic trauma and Schemas, more often than not, the brain convinces people they have ‘healed’ by *just* developing coping strategies—both adaptive and maladaptive. The brain (specifically the amygdala), also perceives and fears it will be a painful experience to address anything to do with the trauma, including healing it. Thus, it will do whatever it can to stop us from healing (e.g., offer up resistance—more on this later).

“I’m working on myself” is another phrase I hear often in speaking with people I encounter in life and from clients. I think it’s a noble thing to say, and this declares to others that we’re practicing self-care that will lead to resolutions that free us from our past. And maybe by saying it out loud to other people makes us feel that just by saying it, we are actually doing something for ourselves. But saying it and actually doing it, are two very different things.

“To learn and not to do is really not to learn. To know and not to do is really not to know.” — Stephen R. Covey

When I’ve dug deeper, more often than not, the person in question has reacted to their issues by employing adaptive and maladaptive coping strategies, especially common maladaptive ones such as ‘avoidance’. What is clear is that they have no clear path, support or process of how to properly heal from their trauma and related behaviours. **Their brain is doing whatever it can to deal with their stressful and traumatic past situation(s) and current reality based on their past, and this is somewhat ‘normal’.**

But I’m here to share with you that there is a choice that can be made, and action that can be taken to go one step further, and heal.

Next, we look at how people cope.

Adaptive & Maladaptive Coping Strategies

While adaptive coping strategies such as Humor (by having a humorous outlook on life, stressful experiences can be and are often minimised) and Social Coping (seeking social support from others) may improve functioning, **a maladaptive coping technique will just reduce symptoms while maintaining and strengthening the issues.** Maladaptive techniques are more common than adaptive coping strategies, but I believe both are *only effective in the short term*, especially when compared to *true healing* (more on this below).

Hundreds of coping strategies have been identified. The following coping strategies interfere with the person's ability to unlearn, or break apart, the paired association between the traumatic experience(s), the associated unhealthy symptoms and their effects on present and future thoughts, words, emotions, actions and behaviours.

This short list exemplifies maladaptive strategies because they serve to maintain effects of the trauma:

- **Dissociation** is the ability of the mind to separate and compartmentalise thoughts, memories, and emotions. This is often associated with PTSD.
- **Sensitisation** is when a person seeks to learn about, rehearse, and/or anticipate fearful events in a protective effort to prevent these events from occurring in the first place.
- **Safety behaviors** are demonstrated when people with anxiety related symptoms come to rely on something, or someone, as a means of coping with their excessive anxiety.
- **Anxious avoidance** is when someone avoids anxiety provoking situations or people that are similar to those who hurt them in the past by all means. **This is the most common method.**
- **Escape** is closely related to avoidance. This strategy is often demonstrated by people who experience panic attacks or have phobias. These people want to flee the situation at the first sign of anxiety.

Understanding Schemas—The Mental Structures That Support Deep Negative Beliefs & The Way You Interpret Yourself, Others and The World

If you suffer from strong negative beliefs about yourself, others or life and durable self-defeating patterns, this section may help you understand why and how these things happen.

Besides learning how you form such negative beliefs, you will also learn how they automatically lead to negative thoughts, devastating feelings and toxic behaviour.

Such deep negative beliefs about yourself and self-defeating patterns most often lead to self-sabotage, low self-esteem, underachievement, depression, or even more serious psychological issues and illnesses.

Examples of such negative core beliefs are:

- I'm unlovable
- I'm such a big failure
- People are cruel
- Nobody cares about me
- Everybody leaves me in the end or will cheat on me
- My needs are never met, etc.

And it all starts with maladaptive schemas and can be caused later in life by trauma and wounding.

In short: You view yourself, others, different situations and the world through schemas. Schemas are mental structures providing a framework for representing some aspect of the world. They are strongly held beliefs that a person has about themselves, about other people, or about the world in general. The belief can be either positive or negative in nature. **In all cases, the schema is accepted as being true, even if its negative and causes harm or difficulties in the person's life.**

They not only help you organise the vast majority of information in a manageable way, they also provide lenses for interpreting reality. Schemas are cognitive structures for screening, coding, and evaluating every stimulus from the environment.

You use schemas to organise your current knowledge, but they also provide a framework for further understanding and action—predicting what will or should

happen in the future. They influence your attention and absorption of knowledge. They also represent your core beliefs and values.

Schemas are like lines of code that run in your brain, giving you instructions for how to interpret things, feel about different events and react. **They create feelings, thoughts and lead you to certain decisions and actions.** That's why schemas are extremely powerful structures.

A schema-focused relationship problem is a pattern of difficulties a person has with others that is caused by these negative beliefs. The theme of these problems often remains the same over time and repeats itself in different types of relationships, including romantic involvements, family relationships, business relationships, and friendships.

The main characteristics of schemas are:

- They are mainly formed in early childhood, youth or adolescence and can be caused by trauma and wounding later in life
- Majority of schemas run on the unconscious level, you are not even aware of them
- They are beliefs and feelings you accept without question, about yourself, others and your future
- The maladaptive schema beliefs are expressed in absolutes (e.g. 'I'm not loveable')
- They are constantly present and very hard to change (especially without therapy)
- They fight for their own survival. In other words, a negative belief about yourself formed in childhood may persist through adulthood even if you invest a lot of effort into changing it by thought alone.

Schemas are valid representations of early childhood experiences, and later serve as templates for processing and defining reactions to different situations. Children hold beliefs about themselves that they learn from their parents and other adults. For example, children who hear judgmental messages such as "You're lazy" or "You're

stupid” will begin to think that these things are true and grow up to be adults who think they are lazy, stupid, or generally incompetent.

Similarly, children who are abused, mistreated, or criticized often think they’ve done something sufficiently bad to deserve their mistreatment—regardless of the fact that none of these unkind comments or actions are deserved. Nevertheless, these children often think poorly of themselves as a result, and may develop the belief that everyone will mistreat them. As adults, these same people continue to think poorly of themselves and their negative schemas continue to grow stronger. Sadly, if left unaddressed, negative schemas don’t change very much throughout life; instead, they continue to be harmful to the person’s self-esteem and relationships.

Repetition compulsion: Once a thinking, feeling or behavioral pattern is established in childhood (a schema), you tend to repeat it over and over. In your adult age, you try to create conditions very similar to those that were the most destructive in your childhood.

Most people have difficulty in at least one or more schema areas, even if they don’t have psychological issues. When I started my journey into all this, I had 6 Schemas present in my reality.

Maladaptive schemas cause us all quite a lot of problems. They negatively distort reality, lead to negative thinking, devastating feelings and ill acting, and they are also the foundation of stereotypes, prejudices and cognitive biases. That’s why understanding maladaptive schemas and how they function can help you **A LOT** in developing a healthier approach to life.

The Schema framework identifies 18 maladaptive schemas that have origins in early relationships and cause all kinds of psychological problems on the thinking, emotional and behavioral level. Before reading the following list, it’s important to note that schemas exist on a spectrum and it’s not *just* simply a case of ‘yes’ or ‘no’ to the idea that a schema is present in your psychology. With that in mind, let’s take a look at the maladaptive schemas and associated unhealthy beliefs:

18 Maladaptive Schemas, Their Effects & Examples of Associated Beliefs

1. Emotional Deprivation

This is a very common schema. If you identify with 5 or more of these statements, you might have the Emotional Deprivation schema:

- I have never really felt emotionally supported.
- I don't expect my emotional needs to be met in my relationships.
- haven't had anyone to rely on for advice or guidance.
- I don't really understand my own emotions or needs.
- I feel like there is a void in my life- something missing but I'm not sure what.
- I haven't really felt special to anyone.
- I rarely share how I feel with other people.
- For most of my life, people have not been there for me emotionally.
- In my childhood, feelings and emotions weren't acknowledged.10 My parents were emotionally distant when I was growing up.
- I often feel a lack of emotional connection with others.
- I believe that my emotional needs are not important or are consistently overlooked.
- I feel misunderstood and not valued in relationships.
- I struggle to identify or express my emotional needs.
- I find myself longing for a deeper emotional bond that I never seem to achieve.
- I feel a persistent sense of emptiness or unfulfillment, even when things are going well.
- I tend to attract relationships where my emotional needs remain unmet.
- I feel isolated and disconnected, even when I am with people.
- I have a history of caretakers or significant others who were emotionally unavailable.
- I often feel like I am on the periphery, watching others experience emotional closeness that is elusive to me.

The effects of Emotional Deprivation:

Emotional deprivation is one of the core primary schemas. This schema is probably one of the most common schemas that people have but it's difficult to detect at first because there often aren't many clear, obvious signs - just a vague sense that something is missing in your life but you're not sure what.

It can feel like an emptiness or a void inside of you that is actually real - it's the emptiness of unfulfilled emotional needs.

It develops very early on in childhoods where the mother (or whoever was the main care-giver) was not emotionally 'in tune' with your needs.

Perhaps you had all your physical needs met, perhaps you had toys to play with, but no one actually paid attention to your feelings and emotional needs.

This situation is extremely stressful for a young child and if this happened to you, you would have developed certain ways to try and make sense of the feelings that you had. When our emotional needs are not met - we feel invisible, unimportant, and not cared for at a deep level.

We basically feel like we don't matter. We don't feel connected to the people around us. And this can lead us down a few different paths:

We start to tell ourselves that there must be something wrong with us - that we are flawed or defective in some fundamental way - and the Defectiveness & Shame schema develops. Or we start acting in ways that will make us feel better about ourselves - we start to try and get people to like us - and the Approval Seeking schema is born.

Emotional Deprivation can profoundly affect your life in various ways:

Persistent Loneliness: Despite being surrounded by people, you might feel alone because your emotional needs are unmet.

Relationship Issues: You may find yourself in unfulfilling relationships or avoid relationships altogether to prevent further disappointment.

Self-Esteem Problems: Continuous emotional neglect can lead to feelings of unworthiness or a belief that you are inherently flawed.

Difficulty Expressing Needs: You might struggle to articulate or even acknowledge your emotional needs due to a lack of experience in having them validated.

Seeking Approval: To compensate for the lack of emotional nourishment, you might seek validation and approval from others, often to the detriment of your own well-being.

One very common off-shoot of Emotional Deprivation is Self Sacrifice Schema.

Psychological Insights:

This schema often stems from early childhood experiences where emotional needs were consistently ignored or dismissed. It's rooted in the fundamental human need for connection, validation, and emotional safety.

Potential Causes and Development:

Early Caregiver Dynamics: Growing up with caregivers who were emotionally distant, preoccupied, or dismissive can lead to this schema.

Traumatic Events: Experiences of loss, neglect, or emotional abuse can reinforce the belief that one's emotional needs are unimportant or burdensome.

Cultural or Familial Norms: Coming from a background where emotions were not openly discussed or valued can contribute to this feeling of deprivation.

Long-term Implications:

Living with this schema can lead to chronic feelings of loneliness, relationship dissatisfaction, and an ongoing struggle with self-worth. It can also lead to secondary issues like anxiety, depression, or staying in unhealthy relationships out of a fear of being alone.

Beliefs:

'My emotional needs are never going to be met.'

'It's futile to express what I feel because no one truly cares.'

'I am fundamentally alone and disconnected.'

Addressing the Schema:

'Nobody will ever love me. Nobody understands me. Nobody cares how I feel. I feel no one can help me out with my problems, issues or goals.'

Overcoming Emotional Deprivation involves recognizing your right to have emotional needs and learning to express them. Therapy, particularly focusing on relational or attachment issues, can be beneficial. Building a support network of understanding friends or finding a nurturing partner can also help. Practices that promote self-awareness and self-compassion, like mindfulness and journaling, can aid in understanding and articulating your emotional needs more effectively.

2. Abandonment / Instability

This is a very common schema. If you agree with 4 or more of the following statements, the chances are you have this schema and it's negatively affecting your life.

- I tend to cling to people if I think they are pulling away from me.
- I get really anxious if I don't know where my partner is or what they are doing.
- I tend to become quite obsessive in relationships.
- I am always looking for signs that my partner's feelings are changing.
- I get so anxious in relationships I tend to sabotage them early on or avoid them all together.
- I often find myself in relationships with people who can't be there for me in a committed way.
- The adults in my childhood were unpredictable - nice one minute, then abusive, cold or distant the next.
- I tend to keep my feelings and needs to myself - I worry that if I show my partner who I really am, they will leave me.
- I feel like it's only a matter of time before relationships end - people usually leave me
- I find it difficult to focus on my own life when I am in a relationship.
- I feel panic or intense anxiety when I think someone I care about is withdrawing from me.
- I'm constantly worried about my loved ones' whereabouts and feelings towards me.
- My relationships are often intense and tumultuous because I fear being left.
- I scrutinize every small change in someone's behavior as a sign they might leave.
- I sabotage my relationships out of fear they will inevitably end.
- I gravitate towards partners who are unavailable or inconsistent.
- I grew up with caregivers who were emotionally unpredictable or physically absent.
- I suppress my true feelings and needs because I fear showing my true self will drive people away.
- I live in anticipation of rejection and feel that it's just a matter of time before my relationships fall apart.
- My preoccupation with abandonment makes it difficult for me to focus on my own life and needs.
- How it affects your life:

How it affects your life:

The Abandonment Schema is the primary reason why we get anxiety in relationships. It develops at a very young age primarily when our care-givers are unpredictable in their love and attention. This might be because of mental health issues, addictions, emotional instability or because they are stressed and overworked.

It can also develop if we were actually abandoned or were separated from our caregivers for a prolonged period of time because of hospitalisation or other reasons.

When this happens we start to develop the beliefs that people will not be there for us consistently and that at anytime they could leave us or abandon us. We never really develop an innate sense of safety around relationships.

Because of the unpredictability or abandonment by the care-givers in our lives, our brain's threat/fear radar - the amygdala - becomes hyper-sensitive at a very young age and gets activated when we are in relationships - especially with people who are similar in traits to our primary caregivers.

The amygdala basically 'recognises' the characteristics of unpredictability or emotional unavailability in a partner and sets off the fight or flight response - which we experience as anxiety and insecurity.

The abandonment schema, like all schemas is SELF-PERPETUATING. The very things we do to try to try and hold on to the relationship can bring about its end, strengthening the core beliefs that we will always be left or abandoned.

How the Abandonment/Instability schema can significantly disrupt your life:

Persistent Anxiety: Constant worry about being left can lead to chronic stress and anxiety.

Relationship Patterns: You might find yourself in a cycle of intense, unstable relationships or avoiding closeness altogether to prevent potential pain.

Self-Sabotage: Fear of abandonment may lead you to end relationships prematurely or behave in ways that push others away.

Emotional Rollercoaster: Experiencing extreme highs and lows in relationships, feeling ecstatic when things are good and devastated at any hint of distance.

Dependency Issues: You might become overly dependent on others for reassurance, struggling to maintain a sense of self when alone.

Psychological Insights:

This schema typically develops in early childhood, often due to inconsistent or unreliable caregiving. It's also reinforced by societal norms that equate constant availability with care and love, further complicating the individual's perception of normal relationship dynamics.

Typical behaviors of this schema are:

- clinging to significant others
- becoming possessive and controlling
- unhealthy levels of jealousy
- constantly asking for reassurance
- becoming hyper-focused on significant others to the exclusion of other people
- hyper-vigilance - always looking for signs that the end of the relationship is near.

Some people will avoid relationships completely or sabotage them early on because the anxiety that relationships generate is too much to handle.

Aside from anxiety, there's also a lot of sadness and depression when there is an actual or perceived end to a relationship and sometimes anger at the people who have left us. However we act with regard to this schema, we rarely experience a fulfilling satisfying relationship. We either end it ourselves or we push people away. So our very fears of abandonment come true - strengthening the core schema belief that people always leave us.

The abandonment schema is often linked to other schemas. When it's linked with subjugation, we believe that if we don't do what other people want they will leave us. When it's linked with the dependency schema, we're terrified that we won't be able to survive on our own. If it's linked to defectiveness and shame, we worry that people will leave us when they find out how defective we are. Like all schemas, because of the difficult emotions we frequently experience, we are prone to addictions as it's the only way we can get some relief from the constant anxiety. We might use alcohol to quell the anxiety or food to fill the void created by the unmet need for connection.

Potential Causes and Development:

Inconsistent Caregiving: Growing up with caregivers who were loving one moment and distant or punitive the next can plant the seeds of this schema.

Early Loss or Separation: Early experiences of loss or separation from a caregiver can leave a lasting impression, leading to fears of abandonment in adult relationships.

Trauma: Traumatic events, especially those involving betrayal or neglect, can significantly contribute to the development of this schema.

Long-term Implications:

Living with an abandonment schema can lead to a lifetime of unstable relationships, chronic anxiety, and an enduring sense of insecurity. It can result in a self-fulfilling prophecy where the fear of abandonment actually drives behaviors that push others away, reinforcing the belief that one is inevitably going to be left.

Beliefs:

'Other people will take advantage of me in some way , etc. Lying, cheating, etc.). I'm always getting the short end of the stick. More often than not, people are abusive and like to hurt others'

'People I love will always leave me.'

'If I show my true self, people will find me unlovable and leave.'

'I must cling tightly to those I care about, or they will disappear.'

Addressing the Schema:

Addressing the Abandonment/Instability schema involves therapeutic intervention, often focusing on building a secure sense of self, learning healthy attachment styles, and developing trust in others. Techniques might include cognitive-behavioral therapy to challenge and change the underlying beliefs, and dialectical behavior therapy to manage intense emotions and improve relationships. Mindfulness and self-compassion practices can also help in alleviating the anxiety associated with this schema. Establishing a stable support system and engaging in consistent, trustworthy relationships can gradually build a more secure attachment style and reduce the fear of abandonment.

3. Mistrust / Abuse

This schema revolves around the belief that others are inherently untrustworthy or malevolent. The expectation that others will hurt, abuse, humiliate, cheat, lie, manipulate, or take advantage. Usually involves the perception that the harm is intentional or the result of unjustified and extreme negligence, trauma or wounding.

If you identify with 5 or more of the following statements, it's likely you're experiencing the Mistrust/Abuse schema:

If you identify with 5 or more of these statements, the chances are you have this schema.

- I feel that other people don't have my best interests at heart.
- I am always on the lookout for people's ulterior motives.
- I find it very hard to trust people.
- At the first sign that someone is against me I end the relationship.
- I never let my guard down, I am always on alert.
- Most people are only out for themselves.
- I tend to end up in relationships with abusive people.
- I feel that in general people don't understand me.
- If I give someone the chance they will take advantage of me.
- If I disclose too much information, people will use it to harm me in some way.
- I am suspicious of others' intentions and believe they are usually self-serving or malicious.
- I am vigilant and always on the lookout for signs of betrayal or deceit.
- I find it extremely difficult to trust people, even those who seem kind or caring.
- I often preemptively end relationships out of fear of being hurt or betrayed.
- I constantly guard myself against being exploited or taken advantage of.
- I believe most people would harm others if they had the chance.
- I frequently find myself in relationships where I feel used or mistreated.
- I feel misunderstood and isolated because others can't be trusted.
- I fear that any vulnerability will be exploited, leading me to withhold personal information.
- I tend to see the world as a dangerous place, full of people waiting to cause harm.

The Mistrust/Abuse schema can profoundly affect various aspects of your life:

Chronic Suspicion: A perpetual state of vigilance and suspicion can lead to constant stress and anxiety.

Relationship Difficulties: Difficulty trusting others can prevent the formation of deep, meaningful relationships and may lead to isolation.

Self-fulfilling Prophecy: By expecting the worst from others, you might inadvertently provoke the very reactions you fear, reinforcing the schema.

Emotional Exhaustion: Constantly guarding against perceived threats can be mentally and emotionally exhausting.

Missed Opportunities: An inability to trust might lead you to miss out on positive experiences and relationships.

Psychological Insights:

This schema often develops from early experiences of betrayal, abuse, or manipulation. It's a defensive mechanism, protecting the individual from being hurt again by preemptively rejecting others.

Potential Causes and Development:

Past Abuse or Betrayal: Personal experiences of physical, emotional, or sexual abuse can be the genesis of this schema.

Unreliable Caregivers: Growing up with caregivers who were deceitful, manipulative, or unreliable can foster a deep sense of mistrust.

Cultural or Environmental Factors: Living in an environment where deceit and manipulation are common can reinforce the belief that others can't be trusted.

Long-term Implications:

Over time, this schema can lead to a lonely and isolated existence, filled with anxiety and suspicion. It can hinder personal growth, relationship development, and overall life satisfaction. Additionally, it may lead to a cycle of abusive relationships, as the individual might subconsciously gravitate towards what's familiar, even if it's harmful.

Beliefs:

'Other people will take advantage of me in some way , etc.lying, cheating, etc.). I'm always getting the short end of the stick. More often than not, people are abusive and like to hurt others'

'People are fundamentally untrustworthy and dangerous.'

'It's only a matter of time before someone betrays me.'

'If I let my guard down, I will be hurt.'

Addressing the Schema:

Addressing the Mistrust/Abuse schema often involves therapy, where strategies like cognitive-behavioral therapy (CBT) can help in challenging and changing destructive beliefs. Building slow, safe, and gradually deeper connections can help in developing a more balanced view of others. Techniques for emotional regulation and mindfulness can reduce the hypersensitivity to perceived threats. Understanding and healing from past traumas with the support of a professional can also be a crucial step in overcoming this schema. It's about learning to discern genuine threats from irrational fears and opening up to the possibility that trustworthiness can exist in relationships.

4. Social Isolation / Alienation

This schema reflects a pervasive feeling of disconnection from others and a belief that one is fundamentally different, not fitting into any group or community. If you resonate with 4 or more of the statements below, you might be experiencing the Social

The feeling that one is isolated from the rest of the world, different from other people, and/ or not part of any group or community.

If you agree with 4 or more of the following statements, you probably have the Social Isolation Schema:

- I feel like I don't fit in.
- I always feel on the outside of groups.
- Growing up, my family was different than other families around us.
- As a child and teenager my family moved around a lot.
- I feel that no one really understands me.
- I just find it so hard to connect to other people.
- People think I'm weird and strange..
- I am a loner.
- I am fundamentally different from other people.
- I have to try really hard to be accepted by others.
- I consistently feel out of place and as if I don't belong anywhere.
- I perceive myself as different from others, not just unique but alien.
- My upbringing or family situation made me feel isolated from my peers.
- Frequent moves or changes in my childhood prevented me from forming lasting connections.
- I feel misunderstood and unable to connect with others on a deeper level.
- Despite my efforts, I find it hard to fit in or be fully accepted by others.
- I feel like an outsider looking in, even when I'm with people.
- I believe that there's a fundamental mismatch between me and the rest of the world.
- I often choose to be alone because trying to fit in is too painful or exhausting.
- I feel a deep sense of loneliness, even when I'm surrounded by people.

How it affects your life:

Social isolation is a very painful schema as it stops us meeting our most fundamental needs - to feel we belong, to feel part of a 'tribe', to feel accepted.

Our brains are social organs - they evolved to live as part of a tribe, and even though our lifestyles have dramatically changed since our hunter gatherer days, our brains are still basically the same and have the same needs.

When we feel different from everyone else, if we feel weird, strange, not part of the groups around us, we will get a profound sense of loneliness.

The emotion of loneliness is our brain's way of signalling to us that we need to connect. But unfortunately, with this schema it's very difficult to connect as we feel so much self-consciousness and anxiety when we are around other people. We can end up feeling like we're stuck between a rock and a hard place. We suffer pain when we're with people and we suffer when we aren't.

It's how we try and cope with these feelings that also causes us a lot of problems. To make it easier to relax in groups and to try and meet our needs for connection, we can often end up using alcohol or drugs. This leaves us vulnerable to addictions as we come to rely on substances to feel 'normal'.

But when we realise that we are becoming addicted, this just adds to our shame of being 'different' from all those 'normal' people out there

Another way we might cope is to avoid people altogether - at least then we only have loneliness and not the feelings of anxiety and shame because we don't fit in. But the loneliness hasn't gone anywhere - it's still there as painful as ever so we might turn to eating to push it down, or alcohol to numb it.

Overtime it is inevitable that we will start to feel depressed - just more emotional pain we have to deal with.

As with all schemas - overtime, the emotional toll is huge - but with social isolation there is no one to turn to.

This schema is one of the main schemas that drive suicide.

The Social Isolation/Alienation schema can profoundly impact your life in several ways:

Persistent Loneliness: Even in the company of others, the sense of disconnection can lead to deep, enduring loneliness.

Difficulty in Forming Relationships: The belief in one's fundamental difference can hinder the formation of close, meaningful relationships.

Social Anxiety and Withdrawal: The fear of rejection or judgment can lead to avoidance of social situations and increased isolation.

Substance Use as Coping: To ease the discomfort of social interactions or to alleviate loneliness, you might resort to alcohol or drugs, potentially leading to dependency.

Depression: Chronic feelings of isolation and loneliness can contribute to the onset of depression.

Psychological Insights:

This schema often stems from experiences that reinforced the notion of being different or not belonging, such as growing up in a family that was markedly different from those around you or being subject to bullying or ostracization.

How do we get it?

Social isolation develops for a number of reasons:

One of the main reasons is if your family of origin was noticeably different from the families around you. This might be because of ethnicity, religion, or financial status. It can also develop if your family moved around a lot so you didn't get the chance to develop deeper friendships and connections. You were always the new kid on the block.

Sometimes it develops if you have a disability, a disfigurement, or a personality style that sets you apart from other children or if you were bullied and ostracised for being different.

Potential Causes and Development:

Family Dynamics: Growing up in a family that was distinct from the norm, whether due to culture, religion, or lifestyle, can contribute to feelings of alienation.

Mobility and Instability: Frequent relocations or changes in living situations can make it difficult to form lasting relationships, reinforcing feelings of isolation.

Bullying or Ostracization: Experiences of being bullied or excluded, particularly during formative years, can instill a lasting sense of being an outsider.

Long-term Implications:

Living with a persistent sense of disconnection can lead to a life marked by loneliness, missed opportunities for meaningful relationships, and a chronic sense of unfulfillment. It can also lead to mental health issues such as depression, anxiety, and in severe cases, can contribute to suicidal thoughts or behaviors.

Beliefs:

'I am very different from other people and I don't belong to any community. I'm an outsider.'

'I am fundamentally different and will never truly fit in anywhere.'

'People will never understand me, and trying to connect is futile.'

'It's safer to be alone than face the pain of rejection or misunderstanding.'

Addressing the Schema:

Addressing the Social Isolation/Alienation schema often involves therapy, where you can explore and challenge deep-seated beliefs about your place in the world. Engaging in community activities or groups where you share common interests can gradually help in forming connections. Therapy, particularly focusing on social skills and combating negative self-perceptions, can be beneficial. Mindfulness and self-compassion practices can help alleviate the self-criticism and loneliness associated with this schema. Over time, developing a more nuanced understanding of oneself and others can lead to a greater sense of belonging and community.

5. Defectiveness / Shame

This schema is driven by the core beliefs of "there is something fundamentally wrong with me" - "I am flawed and defective in some inherent way" "I am not loveable"

If you resonate with several of the following statements, you might be experiencing the Defectiveness/Shame schema:

- I often feel that I am fundamentally flawed in a way others are not.
- I believe that if people knew the real me, they would find me unlovable.
- I am overly sensitive to criticism, seeing it as confirmation of my inadequacy.
- I tend to blame myself for everything, even when it's not my fault.
- I feel a persistent sense of shame about who I am.
- I find myself hiding my true self from others to avoid rejection.
- I often choose partners who are critical or rejecting, as it feels familiar.
- I go out of my way to please others to compensate for my perceived flaws.
- Deep down, I feel unworthy of love and happiness.
- I have a harsh inner critic that constantly puts me down

Where it comes from:

The Defectiveness/Shame schema can have a profound and pervasive impact on your life:

This schema develops in a childhood where where we were abused, neglected, ignored or rejected by the adults in our lives. Whatever treatment we received, we directly or indirectly got the message that we were at fault, or that there was something bad, shameful or flawed about us.

As children, we don't have the capacity to see that our parents or caregivers are at fault - we interpret their abusive or neglectful treatment as being purely down to us. We might think things like - If I was a better child, if I was lovable, I would be loved. It's really tragic as the shame we internalise is not ours to carry - it's toxic shame and it belongs firmly with the adults who mistreated us.

We don't even have to have had any obvious mal-treatment to get this schema. If we had all our physical and material needs met, we had a good education, we had nice holidays etc - we can still get this schema if we didn't have someone to really pay attention to our thoughts and feelings.

As children, the most important emotional needs we have are to feel really seen - to feel like someone gets us, hears us and cares about us. We might intellectually know

that we are loved but we need to feel it. We need to feel that someone holds us in their heart.

In today's society, with all the phones, ipads, video games and general lack of real connection, it's very easy to develop this schema as a child. which is probably one of the reasons that depression is increasing at a rapid rate in young people.

How it affects your life:

This schema is one of the most pervasive - its tentacles reach to all areas of our lives and it prevents us getting a lot of our emotional needs met.

It has a profound effect on our relationships. This schema can prevent us making intimate connections. We are so convinced that there is something wrong with us, we don't want anyone to get to close. As some of my clients have said " If I let them see who I really am, they won't want to know me anymore.

We rarely express our true feelings and needs and so we can end up feeling quite lonely.

We also carry deep feelings of shame which make us feel uncomfortable in our own skin and very self conscious and anxious around other people.

This schema has a very big impact on our emotions and is one of the primary schemas that drives depression. The self-loathing and constant inner critic constantly make us feel like crap .

We generally lack confidence, have low self-esteem and often have body image issues.

Some behaviors typical of this schema are:

- hyper-sensitivity to criticism and rejection.
- devaluing ourselves and allowing others to mistreat us.
- taking the blame for problems that are not our fault.
- choosing critical and rejecting partners.
- staying in dysfunctional relationships because we are 'lucky' that someone puts up with us.

This schema, like other schemas can fuel addictive behaviours, especially with food and alcohol. There are a lot of unmet emotional needs with this schema so we often

try to fill up the void with food or numb the feelings of shame, loneliness and self-loathing with alcohol.

People who have healed this schema feel much more comfortable in their own skin and at ease with people around them. They come to understand that there really is nothing wrong with them - it was their upbringing that was wrong.

The shame is put back where it belongs - on the conditions of their childhood and the people who neglected or abused them.

The Defectiveness/Shame schema can have a profound and pervasive impact on your life:

Relationship Difficulties: Fear of rejection and belief in your unworthiness can lead to dysfunctional relationships or a tendency to isolate yourself.

Low Self-Esteem: The constant belief in your inherent flaw can erode your confidence and self-worth.

Chronic Shame: A pervasive sense of shame can lead to anxiety, depression, and a reluctance to engage in social situations or try new things.

Self-Sabotage: Believing you don't deserve success or happiness can lead you to sabotage opportunities and relationships.

Addictive Behaviors: To cope with feelings of shame and inadequacy, you might turn to food, alcohol, or other substances.

This schema often develops from experiences of abuse, neglect, or constant criticism in childhood. It's a maladaptive way of understanding oneself that's rooted in the past but continues to affect present feelings and behaviors.

Potential Causes and Development:

Abusive or Neglectful Caregivers: Growing up in an environment where you were criticized, ignored, or abused can lead to feelings of defectiveness.

Societal and Cultural Factors: Societal pressures and unrealistic standards can exacerbate feelings of inadequacy and shame.

Bullying or Rejection: Experiences of bullying or rejection, particularly during formative years, can reinforce feelings of being flawed or different.

Long-term Implications:

No part of this book may be reproduced or published in any form or by any means, without permission in writing from the author. Contact shae@shaemattthews.com for more information

(c) 2023 - TCSP™ Healing & Rapid Change Foundation

Living with a defectiveness/shame schema can lead to a life colored by a lack of fulfillment, chronic self-doubt, and an inability to form healthy, supportive relationships. It can also lead to chronic mental health issues like depression and anxiety.

Beliefs:

'I'm internally flawed, inadequate, a mistake. If I let people close, they will realise how flawed I am. I will never have a loving spouse/life partner because I'm so messed up, ugly and/or unlovable'

'I am fundamentally broken and unworthy of love.'

'If people knew the real me, they would reject me.'

'I must strive for perfection to cover up my flaws.'

Addressing the Schema:

Addressing the Defectiveness/Shame schema involves therapeutic work to identify and challenge these deeply held beliefs. Cognitive-behavioral therapy can be particularly effective in examining the validity of these beliefs and developing more adaptive ways of viewing oneself. Building a support system of people who affirm your worth and engage in self-compassion practices can also be crucial steps. Over time, learning to recognize and celebrate your inherent worth can lead to a more fulfilling and authentic life.

6. Failure

This schema centers on a deep-seated belief of personal inadequacy and incompetence, feeling less successful or capable compared to others.

If you identify with 4 or more of the statements below, the chances are you have this schema:

- I feel like I have failed when I compare myself to my peers.
- I feel like I am stupid and incapable of achieving what other people can achieve.
- I don't have much self-confidence.
- I feel ashamed of where I am in my life right now.
- I feel I lack the basic skills I need to be successful in my life.
- I tend to procrastinate when I have tasks to do.
- I end up working much harder than other people to achieve the same results.
- I feel like an imposter in my work.
- I feel like everyone else around me is far more capable than me.
- I don't have any faith in my ability to succeed.
- I constantly feel inadequate compared to my peers or colleagues.
- I believe I lack the intelligence or ability needed to succeed.
- I have low self-esteem and frequently put myself down.
- I am embarrassed by my current life situation and feel I should be further along.
- I perceive myself as lacking crucial skills that others possess.
- I often procrastinate, fearing that any effort I make will result in failure.
- I feel I must work excessively hard to achieve what comes naturally to others.
- I suffer from "imposter syndrome," feeling like a fraud in my achievements.
- I see others as inherently more capable and competent.
- I have little to no faith in my own ability to succeed and make meaningful progress.

This schema is characterised by a deep belief that you are a failure when compared to other people. It could apply to any area of your life such as career, relationships, finances or to your life in general.

How it affects your life:

If you have this schema you will feel that you are fundamentally inadequate or incompetent and you might call yourself stupid, a loser, ignorant, or pathetic.

You might actually avoid trying anything at all because you assume you will fail or you could go to the other extreme and push yourself harder and harder.

If it's in relationships you might give up on them and decide to spend your life alone or if it's around careers you could end up staying in a job that is way below your potential. You will very likely procrastinate a lot and not start or finish tasks and projects because you fear that you are going to fail.

Or you might become a workaholic pushing yourself harder and harder to overcompensate for your perceived lack of talent.

But essentially this schema causes us to live well below our potential and this can leave us with feelings of hopelessness and depression.

This schema, like most schemas, is at the core of many addictive behaviours as we come to rely on certain substances to suppress or numb the painful feelings that the schema generates.

We might also use certain drugs to boost our self confidence and self esteem - two casualties of this schema.

A lot of my clients with cocaine or meth addiction have this schema and they use the drugs to help them feel better about themselves - more confident, more self-assured - albeit temporarily.

With this schema you are likely to have a strong inner critic - a voice in your head that relentlessly beats you up leaving you with deep feelings of self-loathing.

Failure schema can develop under a number of different childhood conditions.

One way this develops is when we have parents or people in our lives who ridiculed, mocked, devalued or criticised our efforts. If we're told again and again that we're no good, that what we do is just not good enough, we will internalise those messages deep in our subconscious brain and they will run like a background track to our lives.

Another way this schema takes hold is if we had attention problems due to high levels of stress. If we had an abusive or neglectful childhood, we would have spent a lot of our childhood in a 'fight or flight' state.

Often this is labelled as ADHD but usually it's the result of a heightened stress response and when we're in this state, it's very difficult to stay still, focus and concentrate.

The Failure schema can significantly affect various aspects of your life:

Chronic Self-Doubt: A persistent belief in your inadequacy can lead to constant self-doubt and second-guessing.

Avoidance of Challenges: Fear of failure may lead you to avoid taking risks or trying new things, limiting personal growth and opportunities.

Procrastination: The dread of failure often leads to avoidance and procrastination, further reinforcing the belief in one's incompetence.

Imposter Syndrome: Even when you achieve success, you might feel like a fraud, unable to internalize accomplishments.

Depression and Anxiety: The constant feeling of inadequacy can contribute to depression and anxiety, impacting overall well-being and quality of life.

Psychological Insights:

This schema often develops from experiences of excessive criticism, unrealistic expectations, or repeated failures that weren't properly contextualized or supported. It's a maladaptive belief system where one's worth is tied directly to their achievements or productivity.

Potential Causes and Development:

Critical or Unsupportive Caregivers: Being raised in an environment where efforts were routinely criticized or devalued can foster this schema.

Comparative Environment: Growing up in a competitive atmosphere, whether in school, sports, or other areas, where comparison was emphasized over personal growth.

Trauma or Repeated Failures: Experiences of significant failures or trauma, particularly if they were publicly shaming or not constructively addressed, can contribute to the development of this schema.

Long-term Implications:

Living with a persistent sense of failure can lead to a life characterized by unfulfilled potential, chronic unhappiness, relationship difficulties due to self-esteem issues, and possibly mental health disorders like depression and anxiety.

Beliefs:

'I'm incapable of performing as well as my peers. Whatever I try, I will fail. I feel stupid and untalented.'

'I am a failure and can't do anything right.'

'No matter how hard I try, I will never be as good as others.'

'It's better not to try than to try and fail.'

Addressing the Schema:

Addressing the Failure schema involves therapeutic work to reconstruct one's belief system and self-image. Cognitive-behavioral therapy can help identify and challenge the negative thought patterns and beliefs. Building small, attainable goals can gradually help in overcoming the fear of failure and boosting self-confidence. Focusing on effort rather than outcome can shift the perspective from failure to learning and growth. Mindfulness and self-compassion practices can also be crucial in alleviating the harsh self-criticism associated with this schema. Understanding the origin of these beliefs and working to internalize a more balanced view of oneself and one's capabilities can lead to a more fulfilling and less fear-driven life.

7. Dependence / Incompetence

This schema is characterized by a belief in one's own incapability to manage daily life and responsibilities without extensive assistance. If you identify with 3 or more of the following statements, you might be experiencing the

Belief that one is unable to handle one's everyday responsibilities in a competent manner, without considerable help from others (e.g., take care of oneself, solve daily problems, exercise good judgment, tackle new tasks, make good decisions). Often presents as helplessness.

If you identify with 3 or more of these statements, you are very likely to have this schema.”

- I find it difficult to cope with every day situations.
- I need other people to get by in life.
- I find it hard to make decisions.
- I don't have much common sense.
- I don't trust my own judgement.
- I am constantly asking people for help and advice.
- I procrastinate and put off dealing with important tasks.
- I worry I won't know what to do if something goes wrong.
- I worry excessively about problems arising.
- I feel like I don't have any control in my life.
- I often feel overwhelmed by everyday tasks and responsibilities.
- I rely heavily on others to make decisions and guide me through life.
- I struggle to trust my judgment and frequently second-guess myself.
- I feel inadequate and lacking in the common sense others seem to have.
- I'm often asking for advice, even for small issues, fearing I'll make the wrong choice.
- I tend to procrastinate and avoid tasks, worried I won't handle them correctly.
- I'm constantly anxious about making mistakes and the possible consequences.
- I feel powerless and out of control, believing I can't manage life on my own.
- I excessively worry about facing new challenges or changes.
- I perceive life as an overwhelming series of tasks I'm not equipped to handle.

How it affects your life:

The Dependence/Incompetence schema can significantly impact various aspects of your life:

Limited Independence: Constant reliance on others can limit your independence and hinder personal growth.

Avoidance of Responsibilities: Fear of failure might lead you to avoid taking on responsibilities, reinforcing the belief in your incompetence.

Relationship Strain: Over-reliance on others can strain relationships, leading to frustration or resentment from both sides.

Low Self-Esteem: Chronic feelings of inadequacy can erode your self-esteem and self-confidence.

Anxiety and Stress: Persistent worry about your abilities and potential problems can lead to high levels of anxiety and stress.

Psychological Insights:

This schema often develops from experiences where autonomy wasn't encouraged or was actively discouraged. It can also stem from overly critical or protective caregiving, where mistakes are met with criticism or tasks were taken over by others, preventing the development of self-reliance.

Potential Causes and Development:

Overprotective Caregiving: Being raised by overly protective or controlling caregivers can prevent the development of independence and self-reliance.

Criticism and Comparison: Growing up in an environment where efforts were constantly criticized or unfavorably compared to others can foster a belief in one's incompetence.

Trauma or Failures: Experiences of significant failures or traumas, especially if they were publicly shaming or not constructively addressed, can contribute to the development of this schema.

Long-term Implications:

Living with a persistent sense of dependence and incompetence can lead to a restricted life, characterized by unfulfilled potential, chronic anxiety, and dependency on others for

basic functioning. It can also lead to social isolation and difficulties in personal and professional relationships.

Beliefs:

'I can't handle life on my own.'

'Making decisions is too difficult for me; I will always make the wrong choice.'

'I need others to guide me and tell me what to do.'

I'm not able to deal with life and take care of myself properly. The day-to-day responsibilities are just too hard. Life is so demanding.'

Addressing the Schema:

Addressing the Dependence/Incompetence schema involves therapeutic work to build self-efficacy and autonomy. Cognitive-behavioral therapy can help challenge and change the deep-seated beliefs of incompetence and helplessness. Gradually taking on more responsibilities and setting small, achievable goals can help build confidence and a sense of capability. Developing problem-solving skills and decision-making strategies can foster a greater sense of independence. Mindfulness and self-compassion practices can alleviate the anxiety associated with new tasks and reinforce a more positive self-view. Over time, learning to trust oneself and one's capabilities can lead to a more autonomous and empowered life.

8. Vulnerability to Harm or Illness

This schema is characterized by an enduring belief in imminent catastrophe, danger, or illness. If you agree with 3 or more of the following statements, you likely experience the Vulnerability to Harm or Illness schema:

- I have a constant feeling of dread that something bad is going to happen.
- I tend to have a lot of 'What if...' thoughts.
- My predominant feelings are anxiety and tension.
- I feel that the world is a dangerous place.
- I often worry that I might have a panic attack.
- I sometimes think I might go crazy.
- My thoughts feel like they are running at 100 miles an hour.
- I worry that I have a terminal illness or that I am going to have a heart attack even though there is no evidence for this.
- I worry about the bad things that are happening in the world.
- I worry about losing all my money and ending up destitute.
- I am constantly anxious about potential disasters or illnesses that could strike at any moment.
- I often engage in 'what if...' thinking, imagining the worst-case scenarios in vivid detail.
- I live in a state of anxiety and tension, always on edge for the next bad thing to happen.
- I perceive the world as an inherently dangerous place filled with threats.
- I frequently worry about having serious, undiagnosed medical conditions despite lack of evidence.
- I am concerned about having panic attacks or losing control of my mental faculties.
- My mind races with thoughts of danger and precaution, never resting.
- I am deeply concerned about global events and their potential impact on my safety.
- I worry excessively about financial ruin or being left destitute.
- I feel the need for constant reassurance from others about my safety and well-being.
- How it affects your life:

How it affects your life:

Obviously this schema is the cause of a great deal of anxiety and stress. The brain's threat radar the 'amygdala' has become hyper-sensitive and sees potential danger everywhere, even if the probability of something happening is really low.

This schema is often at the heart of most of the anxiety disorders, Generalised Anxiety Disorder (GAD), Panic Disorder, Phobias, especially Agoraphobia (fear of open spaces).

OCD is also very common with this schema as we can end up performing rituals to ward off any potential harm

Because of the anxiety, we end up constantly looking for reassurance.

If our concerns are around health, we end up scouring the internet looking up symptoms, or constantly checking our body for signs of illness - which just makes our anxiety worse. We also might repeatedly ask other people what they think - hoping that what they say will make us feel less anxious.

We also end up restricting our life. We might be afraid to go out in case we have a panic attack - we might become phobic of certain situations such as flying or travelling to far away from home.

This schema can have a serious effect on our health due to the constant stress and lack of sleep that comes from not being able to control our thoughts.

Relationships can also suffer as we are never relaxed or fully present. It's difficult to have fun when we are so worried about things.

We can also end up putting a lot of responsibility on our partners - relying on them to make us feel safe and secure.

Chronic anxiety over time can lead to depression as our stress system collapses due to over-stimulation.

So we can end up lethargic, unmotivated, and not wanting to engage with the world. Sometimes we can end up living a very isolated life - afraid to go anywhere or experience anything.

Pervasive Anxiety: Living in constant fear and anticipation of danger leads to chronic anxiety and stress.

Avoidant Behavior: You might avoid activities or situations you perceive as risky, limiting your experiences and quality of life.

Obsessive Checking: Continuously seeking reassurance or checking for signs of illness can become compulsive, interfering with daily life.

Strained Relationships: Your constant need for reassurance and safety can burden relationships, making it hard for partners or friends to relax around you.

Health Issues: Chronic stress and anxiety can lead to actual physical health problems, creating a self-fulfilling prophecy of illness and discomfort.

Psychological Insights:

This schema often develops in an environment where fear and over-protection were prevalent, leading to an exaggerated perception of danger. It's reinforced by the brain's natural negativity bias, where threats are noticed and remembered more readily than non-threats.

Potential Causes and Development:

Overprotective Caregiving: Being raised by parents who were excessively fearful and protective can instill a deep sense of the world being a dangerous place.

Exposure to Trauma or Fear: Experiencing or even just hearing about traumatic events frequently can heighten one's sense of vulnerability.

Inherited Anxiety: Sometimes, a predisposition to anxiety and fear can be inherited, making one more susceptible to developing this schema.

Long-term Implications:

Living with a constant fear of harm or illness can lead to a restricted and anxious existence, where genuine enjoyment and relaxation are rare. It can also cause physical health problems due to the stress and lead to social isolation if the fear becomes too overwhelming.

Where it comes from:

This schema - unlike most others - does not come from abuse or neglect. It tends to come from growing up with parents who were very fearful themselves and over-protective.

They would have probably hovered over you telling you to be careful all the time. You would have grown up in an environment that seemed 'dangerous' because of the tension and worry that was around you. Your amygdala would have been on constant alert and so would have become over-sensitive and hyper-reactive.

If one of your parents was constantly worrying, and talking about all the terrible things that can happen in life -those thoughts would have become wired into your brain as

the 'truth' . So you have ended up with a brain that thinks it is living in a very dangerous world and it's doing its best to keep you alive.

Beliefs:

'There's a big catastrophe waiting for me around the corner (financial, emotional, natural, criminal, etc.). I need to heavily protect myself.'

'Disaster is always just around the corner, and I must be prepared.'

'The world is a dangerous place, and I am vulnerable to its threats.'

'I can't trust that I am safe; something bad is bound to happen.'

Addressing the Schema:

Addressing the Vulnerability to Harm or Illness schema often involves therapeutic interventions like cognitive-behavioral therapy to challenge and reframe catastrophic thinking.

Techniques to manage anxiety, such as mindfulness and relaxation strategies, can reduce the physiological response to perceived threats. Gradually exposing yourself to feared situations in a controlled manner can help build confidence and reduce avoidance behaviors.

Understanding the difference between legitimate caution and irrational fear is crucial in regaining a sense of control and safety. Building a supportive network that understands your fears but also encourages rational thinking and behavior is also key to overcoming this schema.

9. Enmeshment / Undeveloped Self

The Enmeshment Schema is a deeply ingrained psychological pattern that significantly impacts an individual's emotional well-being, sense of identity, and relationships.

This schema often arises from relationships where individuality wasn't encouraged or was actively stifled, typically in families where a parent's needs overshadowed the child's. It reflects a survival strategy where merging with another's identity seemed the only way to gain love and approval.

If you find yourself resonating with 3 of the statements mentioned, it's likely that you're experiencing this schema. Here's a comprehensive understanding of how it can affect your life and shape your perception:

- It's difficult for me to maintain boundaries with my parents.
- My parents are over-involved in my life.
- I am often very much affected by my parent's or partner's emotional state.
- If my parents or partner are unhappy - I am unhappy.
- I find it difficult to meet my own needs if they conflict with my parents or partner.
- Sometimes I don't feel like my life is my own.
- I am so close to my parents or partner that it's hard to feel like I have my own identity.
- I feel obliged to tell my parents all the intimate details of my life.
- I have trouble holding on to my sense of self in intimate relationships.
- I often feel suffocated when I am around my parents.
- 'I can't survive or be happy without this person.'
- 'My needs and desires are less important than keeping the peace in this relationship.'
- 'If I assert myself, I will be abandoned and alone.'

How it affects your life:

If you have the enmeshment schema you will be completely wrapped up in someone else's life to the point where it's difficult to know where they end and you begin. This person is usually a parent but it could also be a parental figure such as a partner, sibling, or best friend.

Your focus will be exclusively on the needs and feelings of the other person - to the detriment of your own. Sometimes this can feel like extreme closeness but for some people it can feel like 'suffocation' especially if the other person is a parent.

You will be very affected by the other person's feelings - when they are down, you are down. When they are happy, you are happy. Their successes feel like your successes.

Their failures, as if you had personally failed.

The problem here is that your emotional state and sense of well being is very dependent on how someone else feels and this a dangerous place to be. You will have no sense of control over your own emotions.

With this schema, you don't develop a stable sense of self and so you will feel like your life is not your own. You don't have a sense of direction or purpose to your own life - you follow the direction and purpose of the person you are enmeshed with.

Because you don't pay attention to your own needs - your life can end up feeling very empty and unfulfilled.

I frequently see this schema in clients who have been brought up with narcissistic parents. Growing up, their parent(s) prevented them from expressing their own needs and feelings either through manipulation or abuse. They became an extension of their parent's emotional state

These children are made to feel responsible for their parent's needs and made to feel guilty or selfish if their parents were suffering in anyway.

Trying to separate from a parent like this causes a great deal of guilt and shame and there is often a lot of repressed anger at the abusive parent that can show up as depression or anxiety.

Potential Causes and Development:

Overinvolved Caregivers: Having a parent or caregiver whose emotional needs dominated the relationship.

Lack of Role Models: Growing up without examples of healthy, independent relationships.

Emotional Manipulation: Being in a relationship where expressing individuality was met with guilt, withdrawal, or manipulation.

Long-term Implications:

Living with this schema can lead to a life where personal goals and potential are significantly compromised. Relationships can be fraught with tension, and the fear of losing the enmeshing relationship can lead to enduring unhealthy dynamics.

Understanding the Enmeshment Schema:

Blurred Boundaries: Maintaining healthy boundaries becomes challenging. Your life might feel intertwined with that of your parent or partner to an extent where individual identities seem blurred.

Overbearing Involvement: An over-involved parent or partner can make it difficult for you to make independent decisions, leaving you feeling like your life isn't entirely yours.

Emotional Echo: Your emotional state becomes a reflection of the other person's feelings. Their happiness is your happiness, and their sorrow becomes yours, leading to a lack of emotional autonomy.

Identity Crisis: The enmeshment often leads to an undeveloped or confused sense of self. You might struggle to recognize your own needs, desires, and emotions as separate from those of the enmeshing individual.

Suffocation vs. Closeness: While some perceive this closeness as comforting, it can also feel suffocating, especially if the enmeshing individual is a parent or authority figure.

Life Direction: Your life may lack a personal direction or purpose as it becomes centered around the needs, desires, and direction of the other person.

Emotional Dependency: Your emotional well-being and self-worth become contingent upon the other person's mood and approval, leading to a lack of control over your own emotional state.

Addressing Enmeshment/Undeveloped Self involves:

Recognizing Enmeshment: Acknowledge the unhealthy dynamics and how they've impacted your sense of self.

Setting Boundaries: Learn to set and maintain healthy boundaries, understanding that doing so is essential for your well-being and growth.

Identity Exploration: Engage in activities and pursuits that help you discover and express your individuality.

Building a Support System: Cultivate relationships outside the enmeshed one to gain perspective and support.

Therapy: Professional help can be crucial in untangling from enmeshment and building a stronger sense of self.

Self-Compassion: Understand that change takes time and practice self-compassion throughout your journey to independence.

While enmeshment can deeply affect your life and sense of self, recognizing and addressing it is a powerful step toward a more autonomous and fulfilling existence. You have the right to your individuality, and with support and effort, you can develop a stronger, more independent self.

The Impact of Narcissistic Upbringing:

Children brought up by narcissistic parents often find themselves deeply enmeshed. They are made to feel responsible for their parent's emotional well-being, leading to suppressed needs and emotions.

This upbringing can lead to significant guilt and shame when trying to establish independence, with repressed anger manifesting as depression or anxiety.

Beliefs:

'If the other person is not always in a good mood, I must have done something wrong. I feel empty. I would rather spend all my time with my spouse; thus I don't have my own hobbies and friends.'

'I can't survive or be happy without this person.'

'My needs and desires are less important than keeping the peace in this relationship.'

'If I assert myself, I will be abandoned and alone.'

Moving Forward:

Recognizing and Healing

Awareness: Acknowledging the presence of an enmeshment schema is the first step towards healing.

Boundaries:

Learn and practice setting healthy boundaries. It's crucial for developing a sense of self and emotional independence.

Identity Exploration:

Spend time understanding your own needs, interests, and desires. What makes you, you?

Support System:

Establishing a support system outside of the enmeshed relationship can provide perspective and encouragement.

Professional Help:

Therapy can be invaluable in navigating and healing from enmeshment. Techniques from NLP and inner game strategies can help in rebuilding self-esteem and autonomy.

Self-Compassion:

Be kind to yourself throughout this journey. Healing and unlearning deeply ingrained patterns take time and patience.

Remember, while enmeshment can profoundly impact your life and relationships, recognizing and addressing it is a significant step toward a more autonomous and fulfilling life.

You're not alone in this journey, and support is available. Your feelings are valid, and it's never too late to seek a path that leads to a healthier, more independent you.

Subjugation of needs or emotions

If you identify with 4 or more of these statements then you probably have this schema:

- I have a lot of trouble speaking up for myself.
- I often feel that people treat me like a doormat.
- In my relationships I tend to let other people make the decisions.
- I rarely tell people if they have hurt my feelings or let me down.
- I tend to feel a lot of anger and resentment that I rarely express.
- I tend to please other people so that there won't be conflict or rejection.
- I am afraid that if I let my feelings out I will lose control.
- I tend to be quite passive aggressive.
- I avoid conflict or confrontation at any cost.
- I have difficulty putting up boundaries with people.

How it affects your life:

Subjugation basically prevents us asserting ourselves, putting in boundaries, expressing our feelings and dealing with conflict.

There is a feeling of fear and anxiety around expressing our true feelings and needs because we fear some kind of retaliation, humiliation or rejection.

We also worry that we won't be able to cope with the after-effect of saying how we feel.

Because we don't put boundaries in with others we can often feel taken advantage of, used or disrespected. We end up doing things we really don't want to because we can't say 'no'.

This just ends up causing a build up anger and resentment towards people and ourselves that sometimes explodes out of nowhere.

Or we direct it at the person through passive aggressive ways. We might fail to return calls, ignore people, turn up late, or half-heartedly complete tasks we've been asked to do

Our relationships are never really fulfilling as we are not honest about our thoughts and feelings. We spend a lot of time people pleasing and doing what others want so people never get to see who we really are inside - what we REALLY think, feel and need.

We don't give people the information they need to have a close, intimate relationship with us.

It can feel very lonely when we have this schema, even if we have people around us as we never feel really 'seen' or understood at a deep intimate level.

Our needs for secure attachment and connection are rarely met.

We can end up in abusive relationships either with partners, friends or colleagues because we don't speak up for ourselves and allow people to trample over our boundaries.

This schema has huge effects on our self esteem and self-confidence as we know that we are not being true to ourselves and we end up feeling controlled and disempowered.

Health-wise - we now know that suppression of our emotions has a very damaging effect on our health - especially when we don't express anger in healthy ways.

Repressed or suppressed anger is strongly linked to a number of different cancers

“Extremely low anger scores have been noted in numerous studies of patients with cancer. Such low scores suggest suppression, repression, or restraint of anger. There is evidence to show that suppressed anger can be a precursor to the development of cancer, and also a factor in its progression after diagnosis” (source:

<https://pubmed.ncbi.nlm.nih.gov/11037954/>)

“Extreme suppression of anger was the most commonly identified characteristic of 160 breast cancer patients who were given a detailed psychological interview and self-administered questionnaire” (source:

<https://www.sciencedirect.com/science/article/abs/pii/S0022399975900628>)

Where it comes from:

If you were raised in a household where it was dangerous to express your feelings or speak up you are very likely have this schema.

It's very common in people who have been physically, emotionally or sexually abused. As a child it was in your best interests to stay quiet and small to avoid harm.

If you had a volatile parent or if there was a lot of conflict and stress in the house, you would have associated speaking up with fear, retaliation, or humiliation.

And that pattern is still playing out today.

Beliefs:

'I can't stand up for myself. If I don't submit to other people or do what they want there will be negative consequences — they will get angry, reject me and show me no love. I need to get high/drunk to deal with what I'm feeling.'

No part of this book may be reproduced or published in any form or by any means, without permission in writing from the author. Contact shae@shaemattews.com for more information

(c) 2023 - TCSP™ Healing & Rapid Change Foundation

11. Self-Sacrifice

If 4 or more of these statements describe you - there is a strong chance you have the this schema:

- People usually turn to me for help and advice. 2I. tend to think of others more than myself.
- I will drop everything if someone close to me needs me.
- I give more to other people than I get in return.
- I tend to do things for others because it is easier for me to do it than let them struggle.
- If someone asks me to do something I would feel very guilty saying no.
- I sometimes feel overwhelmed and exhausted from running around doing things for others.
- 8I. find it very difficult to see someone in emotional pain.
- I rarely express my own feelings and needs as I am focused on the other person.
- It is selfish to put your own needs before others.

On the surface Self-sacrifice seems like a good schema to have. It's all about helping other people, being kind, generous and giving. For this reason, a lot of people have a hard time seeing it as a problem and letting it go.

The thing about Self-sacrifice is that it's just TOO much of a good thing. Of course it's good to care about people, to help others in need and to act in selfless ways AT TIMES.

But with Self-sacrifice it's at the expense of our own well-being and causes us to ignore and suppress our own feelings and needs.

Where does it come from?

Self Sacrifice starts in families where a parent or parents were in need of help in some way.

They might have been disabled, emotionally immature, emotionally unstable or struggling with addiction.

Whatever the circumstances were, as a child you might have had to look after your siblings or parents in some way.

Maybe you had to listen to your parent's emotional problems, or take over adult responsibilities at a young age.

Or perhaps you had to pick a drunk parent up off the floor or bring them home from the pub. You probably had to protect your younger siblings in some way - taking them to school, helping them with your homework, making sure they ate and had clean clothes

Your role and identity became that of carer and you probably heard comments like "you're such a good boy / girl - what would I do without you?"

You started to associate self worth and value with ' helping others and being a good person' and this belief became deeply embedded in your subconscious brain along with " I must put other's before myself" and " My needs are not as important as other people's"

With self-sacrifice, the cracks usually start to show later in life.

How it affects your life:

We start to feel tired and worn out from all the running around and helping other people.

More and more people start to rely on us for help and we can end up end up running on empty.

Because others don't give to the extent that we do - anytime we actually ask someone for help we find that people don't reciprocate to the same extent.

This can cause us to feel resentful, unappreciated and undervalued.

But the thing is - because we have identified with not needing others and being able to cope - we find it very difficult to say anything.

It goes against the core of who we are.

On top of this, we're likely to start feeling a deep feeling of emptiness - we have ignored our own needs and desires for so long that we aren't even sure what they are.

All these feelings start to build up - the stress, tiredness, emptiness, resentment, and probably confusion as to what's going on.

Often at this stage we might start using something to make us feel better, medication, food, alcohol or other drugs, which just adds to the problem.

The effect on our health can be quite serious.

A lot of the clients I work with who have Self-sacrifice have auto-immune diseases such as fibromyalgia, or chronic fatigue syndrome.

The constant busyness means our stress response is always elevated, which in turn means our adrenal glands wear out and our immune system is constantly compromised.

Self sacrificers often have a lot of suppressed or repressed anger - which we now know can contribute to the development of certain cancers.

We often get to the stage where there is just nothing left to give.

Beliefs:

'My own needs are not important, the world is suffering too much. When I make a sacrifice, I feel good about myself.'

12. Emotional Inhibition

If you identify with 5 or more of the following statements, it's likely that you have this schema:

- People see me as uptight emotionally.
- I find it difficult to really know what I am feeling.
- I find it embarrassing to express my feelings.
- I'm not very comfortable receiving or giving affection.
- Sometimes I feel that I will be overwhelmed by emotion if I let it out.
- I am afraid that if I let my anger out, I might lose control completely.
- I have a lot of anger and resentment inside me.
- I feel uncomfortable when other people talk about their feelings or become emotional.
- I find it hard to be warm and spontaneous.
- I find it difficult to know what other people are feeling.

The excessive inhibition of spontaneous action, feeling, or communication — usually to avoid disapproval by others, feelings of shame, or losing control of one's impulses. The most common areas of inhibition involve:

- inhibition of anger and aggression;
- inhibition of positive impulses (e.g., joy, affection, sexual excitement, play);
- difficulty expressing vulnerability or communicating freely about one's feelings, needs, etc.; or
- excessive emphasis on rationality while disregarding emotions.

Beliefs:

'I shouldn't show any emotions, because I'll be perceived as weak, I will get embarrassed or harm others. I like kinky sex, but if I tell the guy I'm dating he will think I'm weird or dirty.'

13. Unrelenting Standard / Hyper-criticalness

If you agree with 4 or more of these statements then it's likely you have unrelenting standards:

- No matter what I do I always feel there just isn't enough time.
- I feel stressed and pressured most of the time.
- I need everything to be done to very high standards.
- I have to feel that I am the best in terms of performance.
- I rarely switch off and relax - it feels like such a waste of time.
- My relationships suffer because I push myself and work so hard.
- I tend to drink more than I should because I just can't switch off.
- There always seems like there is more to be done.
- My health is starting to suffer because I am so wound up all the time.
- I get quite irritated and annoyed easily.

How it affects your life:

Unrelenting standards affects us emotionally in a big way. We are constantly stressed and pressured. We feel that there's never enough time and there's always something to be done.

We have high internal standards of how things should be and we are constantly trying to meet them. Because we rarely achieve the perfection we want, we have a tendency to feel very irritable, agitated, annoyed and angry.

We can also feel deep feelings of shame and inadequacy when we fail to reach the often impossible standards we set for ourselves.

Because of the constant stress, we are prone to a range of health issues. The constant adrenaline from being revved up all the time takes its toll on our cardiac system putting us at risk from heart disease and cardiac arrest. Even if we think we have a healthy lifestyle - if we have stress hormones constantly surging through our bodies, no amount of exercise and healthy eating will protect us.

When stress hormones are activated, our immune system is suppressed leaving us susceptible to diseases such as cancer and auto-immune conditions.

Unrelenting standards prevents us meeting the following emotional needs:

Connection and intimacy

It's hard to be in a relationship with someone who has unrelenting standards because they are rarely present - either physically or emotionally. Even when they ARE around they are thinking about what they have done and what they still need to do. It's the schema that leads to workaholism and also often alcohol dependency as there is no way the person can switch off unless they use some kind of mind-numbing substance.

If the unrelenting standards is directed at others, it is hard to be around as people tend to feel that they are never measuring up.

Relaxation and spontaneity

With this schema we can never fully relax and be present in the moment - so we miss out on having fun, feeling joy, satisfaction, contentment and the experience of feeling fully alive and engaged. Because of this, we are susceptible to feelings of emptiness, loneliness and depression in the long term.

This schema is very common in people who are very successful in their careers - they have pushed themselves so hard but when they finally achieve success - it doesn't feel satisfying. They have totally neglected their emotional needs.

Where it comes from:

This schema tends to develop in families where value as a person was equal to how well we do in certain areas.

Very little importance was placed on emotions, having fun, connecting to others and relaxing. Emphasis was placed on performance and doing well.

If you have this schema then you would've got 'love' and attention when you did well in a certain area of your life.

It also comes from families where there was a lot of criticism and very little praise so you never felt that you had done well enough. You grew up feeling that you could always have done better.

Beliefs:

'I must always strive harder, and meet all my high standards. There is a right way to do everything.'

14. Entitlement / Grandiosity

The belief that one is superior to other people; entitled to special rights and privileges; or not bound by the rules of reciprocity that guide normal social interaction. Often involves insistence that one should be able to do or have whatever one wants, regardless of what is realistic, what others consider reasonable, or the cost to others; OR an exaggerated focus on superiority (e.g., being among the most successful, famous, wealthy) — in order to achieve power or control (not primarily for attention or approval). Sometimes includes excessive competitiveness toward, or domination of, others; asserting one's power, forcing one's point of view, or controlling the behavior of others in line with one's own desires — without empathy or concern for others' needs or feelings.

'I'm allowed to do, say or have whatever I want and whenever I want it, regardless of what others think or feel.'

If you identify with 5 or more of these statements, you might have the

- I often feel that I deserve more than others.
- I get frustrated when people don't recognize my special status or abilities.
- Rules that apply to others don't seem applicable to me.
- I feel angry or resentful when I don't receive special treatment.
- I often find myself envying others who have what I believe I deserve.
- I believe I'm destined for greatness and others should recognize this.
- I have a strong reaction to being criticized or challenged.
- I often feel superior to others and believe I am inherently better.
- I insist on having the best of everything, seeing it as a rightful entitlement.
- I manipulate or dominate others to get my way or to maintain a sense of superiority.
- How it affects your life:

Entitlement/Grandiosity can significantly impact your life in numerous ways:

Relationship Strain: Your insistence on special treatment and superiority can alienate friends, family, and colleagues, leading to strained or broken relationships.

Conflict at Work: A belief that standard rules or critiques don't apply to you can create conflict in professional settings and hinder career progression.

Emotional Turmoil: Constantly feeling underappreciated or resentful when others don't recognize your 'specialness' can lead to persistent feelings of anger, frustration, and dissatisfaction.

Social Isolation: Your attitude of superiority and entitlement can lead to social isolation as others may find it difficult to connect with you on an equal and genuine level.

Difficulty with Empathy: A focus on your own needs and desires can impede your ability to understand and care for others' feelings and needs, limiting the depth of your relationships.

Psychological and Sociological Insights:

This schema might stem from various factors, including being excessively pampered or idolized in childhood, receiving mixed messages about one's status and worth, or as a defense mechanism to cope with underlying feelings of inadequacy or vulnerability. Societally, it might be reinforced by cultural narratives around success and superiority.

Potential Causes and Development:

Childhood Experiences: Growing up in an environment where you were either excessively praised without merit or where you had to overcompensate for feelings of inadequacy.

Cultural Influences: Living in a society that glorifies wealth, power, and individualism might also contribute to developing this schema.

Personal Experiences: Encounters that validate your beliefs of superiority or entitlement can reinforce this schema over time.

Long-term Implications:

Persisting in this schema can lead to a life marked by interpersonal conflicts, persistent dissatisfaction, and a possible crisis when external validation wanes or fails. It can also lead to more severe issues like narcissistic tendencies, where the need for admiration and superiority severely impacts all aspects of life.

Beliefs:

'I deserve more than others because I am special.'

'Rules are for people who aren't as capable or intelligent as I am.'

'People should recognize and admire my superiority without me having to prove it.'

Addressing the Schema:

Recognizing and addressing Entitlement/Grandiosity involves self-reflection, possibly re-evaluating self-worth and success, learning to empathize with others, and understanding the value of equality and mutual respect. Therapy, particularly Cognitive Behavioral Therapy (CBT), can help challenge and change these ingrained beliefs and behaviors. Fostering genuine connections and practicing humility can also be steps towards change.

15. Insufficient Self-Control / Self-Discipline

If you identify with 5 or more of these statements, you are very likely to have this schema:

- I get bored and distracted easily.
- I often feel restless and agitated.
- I find it difficult to stick to a plan or follow through on goals.
- I tend to get very excited by new plans then lose interest quickly.
- I find it very difficult to stop self-destructive behaviours such as drinking, smoking and over-eating.
- I find it difficult to tolerate uncomfortable emotions.
- I'm very impulsive and often do things I later regret.
- I often can't hold back and end up reacting to my feelings.
- I find it difficult to focus and concentrate for very long.
- I feel like I have too much energy and find it hard to channel it into anything productive.

How it affects your life:

If you have this schema you will likely struggle with self-discipline and / or self control and this can show up in your life as:

- feelings of restlessness and boredom.
- difficulty following through on plans or goals.
- self - sabotage.
- making instant decisions that you regret later.
- blurting things out without thinking them through.
- emotional outbursts

With this schema your life can be quite chaotic. You will have a very active mind - often called 'the monkey mind' as it flits from one idea to another. You might find yourself getting really excited about a new idea or plan, and then lose interest as soon as you start it. You will find it difficult to maintain focus and concentration so you will be very prone to procrastination. The heart of this schema is a limited ability to tolerate uncomfortable emotions such as frustration, stress, anxiety. As soon as we experience any kind of discomfort we try to get away from it. Unlike other schemas, this schema doesn't really have any core beliefs or thoughts that drive it. It's usually due to underdevelopment of the brain's "executive control" centre - the Pre-frontal Cortex. This part of the brain is responsible for managing our emotions, self-discipline, following through on plans and self-control. It's the braking system of the brain.

There's a few reasons why this part of the brain doesn't develop well.

If we experienced emotional neglect or abuse as children within the first few years of life - the pre-frontal cortex doesn't receive the emotional input it needs to develop to its optimal capacity.

Also if we experienced prolonged stress as a child - the pre-frontal cortex functioning will be compromised. A third reason is that we weren't taught self-discipline as a child. If we had no rules or boundaries, we don't develop the key traits of patience, delaying gratification or tolerating discomfort.

The implications of this schema can be huge.

One of the main impacts is that we find it difficult to finish anything. We might start hundreds of projects with very little accomplishment. The need to feel accomplished is an essential emotional need and when we don't meet it, we end up with feelings of frustration, shame, and inadequacy. We never really feel the deep satisfaction and pride that we get when we persist and finish something successfully. Because we have limited impulse control, we sometimes react to situations without thinking - causing us to damage relationships, lose our jobs or end up with legal problems. We also live at the mercy of our emotions - so we can find ourselves changing our minds a lot and not being able to find or stick to a path throughout life. Or we struggle with fluctuating emotions that we can't get a grip of.

With this schema we are also prone to addictions and depending on what you are using you can end up with all sorts of issues - especially related to your health.

We don't have an internal braking system that tells us when enough is enough.

Overtime, with this schema you can start to feel like you are being buffeted around by life, not really going in any kind of meaningful direction.

You can start to feel like you are a failure and with these thoughts come feelings of inadequacy, shame and depression.

Beliefs:

'Its kind of an addiction, I just can't help myself, I have to do it. I have a big problem setting limits for myself. I have an issue with Sam, but I'm not going to bring it up 'cos I hate confrontation.'

16. Approval-Seeking / Recognition Seeking

If you identify with 3 or more of these statements - there is a strong likelihood that you have this schema:

- I worry a lot about what people think of me.
- Many of my decisions have been based on what other people will think.
- In social situations, I get anxious that people are judging me or don't like me.
- I tend to change how I act and talk depending on who I am with.
- I don't feel like I have a strong sense of identity.
- Lots of praise and attention from others makes me feel worthwhile.
- I want everyone to like me.
- Having money and status is really important to me.
- My self esteem is very dependent on what other people think of me.
- I tend to dwell on what I have said or done, worrying that I might have offended someone.

The Approval Seeking Schema is driven by a deep need to be liked and recognised. It's actually very healthy and normal to want to be liked - it is one of our essential survival needs. Back when we lived in tribes - our only protection was in the safety of the group so if we weren't 'approved' of we would have probably been thrown out and left on our own to perish.

Approval seeking only becomes a problem when it causes us emotional problems or gets in the way of achieving personal fulfilment.

How it affects your life:

With this schema, one of the main problems is the loss of a true sense of self and identity.

We spend so much time and energy trying to work out what will make other people like us that we totally ignore our own true needs, feelings and desires.

We have a strong people pleasing streak - the thought of someone rejecting us or not liking us is just too much to bear so we spend a lot of time trying to work out what other people want from us that will make them like us.

This can be exhausting as we end up constantly ruminating over things we've said or done in case we might have inadvertently hurt someone.

We can end up like a chameleon - always changing who we are depending on who we are with.

Appearances are really important to us , so we can become quite obsessed by our bodies, our hair, our clothes, and our material possessions.

Some of my clients who have this schema say that they can never really relax when they are with others as they are constantly worrying that they might say something that will upset others, come across as stupid or sound boring. This can cause a lot of social anxiety

Emotionally we can end up struggling with low self esteem, feelings of emptiness, loneliness, confusion and eventually depression.

Because we don't really know who we are, we can't really connect with others on a deep intimate level and our need for real connection is rarely met.

This schema also causes a hyper-sensitivity to rejection - which has a huge impact on relationships and on our own emotional state. Sometimes we will see a disagreement or difference of opinion as 'rejection' and lash out at people or get extremely upset and emotional.

We also don't really feel fulfilled in our lives as the majority of choices are not made with our own needs and desires in mind.

We can end up in careers we don't like, relationships that are shallow and superficial, and taking up hobbies purely because they 'are cool' and look good to others.

Where it comes from:

Approval seeking schema develops in families where:

- There was a lot of importance placed on 'keeping up appearances' and on what other people thought.
- Parents were very controlling around what hobbies and interests their children had and what path in school they should take.
- Where love and attention was only given when children 'pleased' their parents in some way.

Basically, as children, approval seekers were not encouraged to develop their own ideas, opinions, likes, dislikes or path through life and so they don't develop a true, stable sense of self.

Beliefs:

'What will other people think of me... I simply must fit in! I will feel better about myself if I impress people.'

17. Vulnerability to Negativity / Pessimism

If you identify with 4 or more of these statements, the chances are you have this schema:

- People have called me pessimistic but I believe I am a realist.
- I find it hard to be happy as I know something bad will eventually happen.
- You can't be too careful as things generally tend to go wrong.
- It's much better to expect the worst than to be constantly disappointed.
- People have said that I am a worrier.
- I tend to think about the dark side of life a lot.
- I am rarely spontaneous and tend to be a creature of habit and routine.
- I find it really difficult to make decisions because a wrong choice could lead to disaster.
- People often tell me to 'cheer up' or 'look on the bright side'.
- I find myself obsessively planning to ensure mistakes don't happen.
- I often get labeled as pessimistic, though I see myself as just being realistic.
- Happiness seems fleeting because I'm aware that bad things can happen at any time.
- I believe in being extra cautious as things usually don't work out.
- Expecting the worst feels safer than facing constant disappointment.
- Others describe me as a worrier.
- My thoughts frequently drift to life's darker aspects and potential problems.
- I prefer sticking to routines and habits because spontaneity feels risky.
- Decision-making is hard for me, as I fear making a disastrous choice.
- People often tell me to be more positive and to look on the bright side.
- I tend to plan obsessively to avoid mistakes and ensure everything goes right.

How it Affects Your Life:

A pervasive, lifelong focus on the negative aspects of life (pain, death, loss, disappointment, conflict, guilt, resentment, unsolved problems, potential mistakes, betrayal, things that could go wrong, etc.) while minimizing or neglecting the positive or optimistic aspects. Usually includes an exaggerated expectation — in a wide range of work, financial, or interpersonal situations — that things will eventually go seriously wrong, or that aspects of one's life that seem to be going well will ultimately fall apart. Usually involves an inordinate fear of making mistakes that might lead to: Financial collapse, loss, humiliation, or being trapped in a bad situation. Because potential negative outcomes are exaggerated, these patients are frequently characterized by chronic worry, vigilance, complaining, or indecision.

- Persistent Negative Outlook: A continual focus on what could go wrong, overshadowing positive experiences.
- Chronic Worry and Anxiety: Constantly anticipating disasters, leading to significant stress and anxiety.
- Avoidance of Risk: Reluctance to try new experiences or take risks due to fear of negative outcomes.
- Decision-Making Difficulties: Indecision and procrastination caused by the fear of making the wrong choices.
- Impact on Relationships: Strain in relationships due to a persistent negative perspective and lack of spontaneity.

Psychological Insights:

- This schema often stems from a deep-seated belief that the world is fundamentally a dangerous and unforgiving place.
- It is fueled by the brain's negativity bias, where negative events have a more significant impact on one's psychological state than positive ones.

Potential Causes and Development:

- Exposure to Negative Influences: Growing up in an environment where negativity, worry, and pessimism were prevalent.
- Past Traumatic Experiences: Personal experiences of failure, loss, or trauma can reinforce a pessimistic worldview.
- Cultural or Familial Patterns: Being part of a family or culture that emphasizes caution and fear of the worst can cultivate this schema.

Beliefs:

- 'It's safer to expect the worst than to hope for the best.'
- 'By anticipating problems, I can prevent them from happening.'
- 'The world is a dangerous place, and bad things are more likely to happen than good.'
- 'If something can go wrong, it probably will.'
- 'Optimism is naïve; realism is expecting things to go badly.'

Addressing the Schema:

- Cognitive Restructuring: Challenging and changing the pessimistic thought patterns through techniques like cognitive-behavioral therapy.
- Developing Optimism: Practicing gratitude and focusing on positive aspects of life to balance the negative bias.

- Exposure Therapy: Gradually exposing oneself to new experiences and risks to build confidence and reduce fear.
- Mindfulness and Acceptance: Learning to accept uncertainty and focus on the present moment, rather than worrying about the future.
- Seeking Support: Building a network of supportive relationships that encourage a more balanced and positive outlook.

Beliefs:

'Things are going quite well, but... everything in my life goes seriously wrong. I feel if I do XYZ it will go bad or I will stuff it up.'

17. Vulnerability to Negativity / Pessimism

If you identify with 4 or more of these statements, the chances are you have the Vulnerability to Negativity / Pessimism schema:

- 'I must conform and excel to be accepted. Others' opinions define my self-worth.'
- 'My value lies in how others perceive me, so I have to impress them at all costs.'
- 'Fitting in and achieving success in the eyes of others is crucial for my self-esteem.'
- 'Expressing my true emotions will lead to rejection or embarrassment.'
- 'I must maintain emotional control at all times to be respected.'
- 'Showing vulnerability is a sign of weakness and should be avoided.'
- 'It's better to keep feelings to myself than to risk being judged or misunderstood.'
- 'Emotional restraint is necessary for maintaining stability in relationships and at work.'

Addressing the Schema (Continuation):

- Emotional Awareness: Engaging in activities or therapies that help in recognizing and understanding one's emotions.
- Safe Expression: Finding safe and controlled environments to express emotions, such as therapy or supportive groups.
- Gradual Exposure: Slowly and gradually practicing emotional expression in personal relationships.
- Reframing Vulnerability: Learning to see vulnerability as a strength and a normal part of human interaction.
- Building Emotional Intelligence: Enhancing the ability to perceive, understand, and manage emotions in oneself and others.

By addressing these schemas with appropriate strategies and beliefs, individuals can work towards a more balanced, fulfilling life, improving their relationships, self-esteem, and overall well-being.

18. Punitiveness

If you identify with 3 or more of the following statements, you probably have this schema:

- When people make mistakes they should be punished and made accountable.
- People need to be told when they have done something wrong.
- I get upset when people are allowed to get away with bad behaviour.
- I find it hard to forgive and forget and tend to hold grudges.
- I beat myself up mercilessly when I make a mistake.
- I find myself dwelling on bad things that other people have done - especially when they won't take responsibility.
- I have a strong critical voice in my head which judges myself and others very harshly.
- For me there is black and white - no middle ground.
- If I don't do the job right - I should suffer the consequences.
- People have told me that I am very critical and judgemental.
- I believe that people must face serious consequences when they err.
- It's important for me to point out others' mistakes.
- I get frustrated and angry when people aren't held accountable for their wrongdoings.
- I have a hard time letting go of resentment and tend to hold grudges.
- When I make mistakes, I am extremely hard on myself.
- I often dwell on the wrongdoings of others, especially if they don't acknowledge their faults.

My inner voice is very critical, judging myself and others harshly.

- I see things in terms of right and wrong, with little room for grey areas.
- I believe in facing harsh consequences for my own mistakes.
- Others have described me as overly critical and judgmental.

How it Affects Your Life:

The belief that people should be harshly punished for making mistakes. Involves the tendency to be angry, intolerant, punitive, and impatient with those people (including

oneself) who do not meet one's expectations or standards. Usually includes difficulty forgiving mistakes in oneself or others, because of a reluctance to consider extenuating circumstances, allow for human imperfection, or empathise with feelings.

- Relationship Strain: Harsh judgments and a lack of forgiveness can create tension and conflict in relationships.
- Self-Criticism: Intense self-punishment for personal mistakes can lead to low self-esteem and self-worth.
- Limited Compassion: Difficulty empathizing with others' mistakes or understanding their perspectives.
- Chronic Anger: Persistent feelings of anger and frustration towards oneself and others.
- Rigid Thinking: A black-and-white mindset that limits flexibility and adaptability.

Psychological Insights:

- This schema often develops from environments where mistakes were met with severe criticism or punishment.
- It might be linked to a deep-seated belief that strictness and punishment are necessary for maintaining order and discipline.

Potential Causes and Development:

- Authoritarian Upbringing: Growing up in a household where strict discipline and punishment were the norms.
- Exposure to Critical Caregivers: Influences from caregivers who were overly critical and demanding.
- Cultural or Societal Norms: Societal values that emphasize strictness, discipline, and accountability.

Beliefs:

- 'Mistakes are unacceptable and must be punished.'
- 'People, including myself, should be held to the highest standards at all times.'
- 'Forgiveness is a sign of weakness.'
- 'There's a clear line between right and wrong, and crossing it should have serious consequences.'
- 'Being critical and judgmental is necessary to maintain order and standards.'

Addressing the Schema:

- Cognitive Reframing: Working to change the rigid beliefs about mistakes and punishment through therapy.
- Developing Empathy: Learning to understand and empathize with the circumstances and challenges of others.

- Practicing Forgiveness: Cultivating the ability to forgive oneself and others, recognizing human imperfection.
- Mindfulness Techniques: Using mindfulness to manage and reduce feelings of anger and frustration.
- Challenging Black-and-White Thinking: Encouraging more flexible and nuanced thinking patterns/
- He should absolutely be harshly punished for making such a mistake. I'm very intolerant and easily lose my temper.'

By addressing the Punitiveness schema with these strategies, individuals can learn to foster more compassionate, understanding, and forgiving relationships with others and themselves, leading to improved mental well-being and interpersonal dynamics. For more detail on Schemas, refer to this page.

Identifying The Maladaptive Schemas

Many times, just reading about the 18 maladaptive schemas above leads to the “aha” moment, where you become aware of the main maladaptive schemas that cause problems in your life.

To further explore the underlying maladaptive schemas, you can additionally **seek answers for the following “should” questions:**

- What should or shouldn't you/I do in a specific situation?
- How should the world function?
- How should you/I behave in a particular situation?
- What should happen in a particular situation?
- How should other people behave towards me?

Additionally, when a specific event happens and triggers a certain schema, you can also understand schemas better by asking yourself the following questions:

- What does the [internal or external] event say about you? e.g. I'm ... a failure,
- What does the event say about other people? e.g. People are ... so critical,
- What does the event say about your life or how the world operates? E.g. The world is ... cruel.

If/when we do the therapy/change work, we use a psychometric testing tool to determine your schemas and their severity.

Might You Be Living in the Past Without Knowing It?

We harbor defeatist attitudes due to earlier insecurities, rejections, and failures. And however unconsciously, our never-resolved self-doubts can easily compromise our future. They do so by restraining us from taking on challenges that could serve to transform false conclusions we (prematurely) came to about ourselves.

Afflicted with such disparaging, undermining beliefs, we can end up achieving far less than what we're potentially capable of. Our self-aversive, out-of-date programming holds us

back from evolving into the person we so much want to be—but may, unawares, have surrendered striving to be.

Let me explain this all-too-common pattern in greater detail:

How you see yourself today may have virtually everything to do with how you were induced to see yourself earlier—from events in your childhood and adolescence, to various disappointments and discouragements you experienced as a younger adult. And the deficits in your self-image were acquired less from your actual behaviour than from how others responded to it. Most importantly, your core sense of self was moulded by how you interpreted the consequences of your words and actions.

Ironically, your interpretation, typically exaggerated or distorted, constitutes the bright side in all of this. After all, you can't alter what you originally did, or what happened to you. Nor can you change the messages about yourself that you received (or thought you received) from family, peers, and anyone else to whom you originally gave authority. But **what you can change is the meaning you formerly attached to whatever feedback you encountered about yourself**. Frankly, if that weren't the case, neither you (nor anyone else) would be able to change at all.

What haunts most of us are the various mistakes we made in the past—mistakes that at the time left us feeling embarrassed, humiliated, degraded, or ashamed. And the worst part of all our missteps is that because they may have represented defining moments in our lives, we may actually have come to define ourselves on their basis. These mistakes were driven by impulse, or reflective of what made sense to us back then. But many of the negative decisions about ourselves and the world they prompted us to adopt were, given our age and maturity, significantly over-generalised. Still, however indirectly, they've been a major influence in determining the present quality of our lives. And, in fact, these faulty, short-sighted conclusions probably exemplify our single biggest mistake of all.

Ask yourself: Because of so many things you wish you hadn't done or, regrettably, were done to you, are you, more or less unawares till now, burdened by such defeatist beliefs as:

- I'm a disappointment
 - I can't compete with others, or I'm inferior
 - I don't measure up, or I'm not smart enough
 - I can't succeed (or don't deserve to)
 - I'm cowardly
 - I'm vulnerable (or unable to protect myself)
 - I'm a victim
 - I'm lazy
 - I'm looked down upon
 - I have nothing to say (or contribute)
 - I don't fit in
 - I'm immature (not really an adult)
 - I can't trust myself (or anyone else)
 - I can't make decisions
 - It's not safe for me to have feelings
 - I can't displease others
 - I have to be responsible for others
-
- I have no authority, etc.

There are hundreds such negative beliefs that, regardless of whether you rationally think— at a gut level you experience them as true. **These pejorative characterisations depict enduring constraints that may be “fixed” inside you, regrettably representing who you, *falsely*, believe you are.**

Do any of these strategies (especially what is listed in the schema system) and/or beliefs seem familiar? IF THEY DO, RIGHT NOW, treat yourself with loving kindness and compassion—*this is not negotiable.*

If you take the step to work with me and if I feel it will be helpful, I use an easy psychometric test where you answer questions with a number from 1 to 6 to help us accurately identify your schemas. From this, part of the plan of clearing and healing is formed.

The Bigger Picture

Trauma, wounding, self-limiting beliefs, schemas and maladaptive coping strategies can affect our worldview—the lenses with which we see reality (typically so we see it as unsafe), our understanding and meaning of life, society, and the world. Traumatic events are often overwhelming. This can make it hard for people who have been through a traumatic event to think through and come to terms with what has happened. The experience is likely to be very different from anything they have gone through before. It can be hard to make sense of what happened, and sometimes it makes people doubt things that they've always believed. For instance, after traumatic experiences such as sexual abuse, a person might no longer believe that the world is a safe place, that people are generally good, or that they are in control of what happens to them and even feel they deserved it. When people talk about their world being shattered after a traumatic event, they are usually talking about these beliefs being shattered.

All types of traumatic events cause emotional and psychological distress for most people and can lead to Post Traumatic Stress Disorder (PTSD). I've had PTSD from a major car accident that lead to debilitating complications as I didn't heal it soon enough. It's a nightmare that I wouldn't wish upon anyone.

Time to explore coping with all of this vs healing from all of this, because yes, even though it may feel overwhelming, **it can be healed.**

Coping vs Healing

You may be thinking: “What’s wrong with just coping?” If so, that’s a very reasonable thought to have.

Let’s unpack what I feel coping *really* is and how it effects our lives.

I feel coping, especially in the long-term, is unhealthy because more often than not people

just manage the symptoms by using various mechanisms: substances, distractions,

mindless activities, self-harm etc — anything to distract themselves from their enormous, often chronic pain they feel deep down inside. They have detrimental effects on physical, emotional and psychological levels. Some would say they even affect us spiritually. Coping strategies tend to have us “doing the best we can with what we’ve got,” i.e. operating the best we can, BUT still *under the controlling influence* of the trauma or wounding.

Often through my experience working with people, people mistake coping as healing as they seem quite similar. The fact of the matter is that they are *dramatically* different. The primary difference between coping and healing is that both require action, but healing is taking things one step further and doing *something* that targets the root of the problem(s).

Coping strategies work *around* the memories, and emotions, of a trauma and wounding, essentially keeping us in victim narrative, while healing tends to go *into* its core to release it and brings us into creator narrative.

A coping strategy is designed to control the effects a trauma/wounding has on our current reality, and our future thoughts, words, emotions and actions on the subconscious level, while feeding directions to our conscious minds. **They do this while tricking us to think these are conscious, rational and healthy choices for our present and future.**

With coping, you are still carrying and holding the pain of the past even if the ‘sting’ has gone. It’s important to understand that the effects of the trauma live on even if you don’t ‘feel’ the sting of the past. For example, someone was cheated on and suffered greatly. As time goes on they don’t feel the suffering any more, BUT, they become distrusting of potential romantic partners and relationships altogether even if deep down they yearn for one, and therefore avoid all relationships while feeling alone and isolated.

They may try to fill this void with just having casual, no strings attached sex because with this kind of sex, their emotions are ‘safe’. With this behaviour, the void is filled

No part of this book may be reproduced or published in any form or by any means, without permission in writing from the author. Contact shae@shaemattews.com for more information

(c) 2023 - TCSP™ Healing & Rapid Change Foundation

temporarily, and in time may feel worse. **Coping is essentially a reactionary response, and on the outside, seems to be positive. In a way they are, but they keep us in a perpetual 'victim' narrative.**

Healing requires going deeper and dispersing the charge of the trauma and the past. **Healing allows you to be 'free' to choose whatever path/action from a positive place, and not a reactionary place.** Using the same example of being cheated on, if you were healed from a relationship trauma, you would be able to happily enter a new relationship unaffected by your past emotional wounding and unafraid of the potential emotional pitfalls. With healing, you carry the lessons you learned from the past with you going into the new relationship while being free of any subconscious or conscious negativity or emotions about relationships. In essence, you are a 'creator,' free to choose a fulfilling future going for what you *really* want, and not leading a life based on reaction.

Why Do We Usually Default to Coping Instead of Healing?

We usually default to coping as the three areas of the brain operate on instinct and are all charged with the same task: 'keep you safe'. **They act as a 'hand-brake' on our thoughts, words, emotions and actions to ensure they do their job—to try and stop us experiencing any more harm. This is a natural reaction; it's an important function of our brain, and is hard wired to our instincts.** Our 'safety' is one of the primary

survival instincts alongside of breathing, consuming nutrients and finding shelter. It makes sense why this mechanism is a big part of our lives. **Unfortunately, this same mechanism offers up resistance to healing in its attempt to keep us 'safe' as anything to do with it (healing or otherwise) is perceived as something 'unsafe'— strange but true.**

When it comes to the core instincts I have outlined (which coping is one of), the brain automatically kicks into gear with these strategies after experiencing a trauma or wounding. It's unfortunate that the brain isn't naturally equipped to properly heal from trauma, as **actual healing isn't instinctual.**

The unfortunate side-effect of this is that we suffer in our present 'comfort zone' and future. We might be able to operate temporarily in a more functional fashion with coping strategies, but the trauma, wounding or schema can still be consciously, or unconsciously, controlling our perception and experience of reality in all its forms.

The False Comfort Zone

Who doesn't want to be comfortable? I love it when I have everything I need, when I'm relaxed, when I'm sitting in a cozy chair and I feel at ease with the people I'm with. All is well. But there is this imaginary place we call our "comfort zone".

Let's explore this idea of a comfort zone to see if it is actually supporting you and your happiness. What is it exactly?

- It is not a real place. It is an idea created by you.
- Its function is to keep you feeling safe.
- It is what you know and are familiar with in all areas of your life—relationships, choices
- How you spend your time—even thoughts patterns and feelings.
- It excludes things you are afraid of, uncomfortable with or have anxiety around.

Your comfort zone doesn't sound like a bad place to be—unless you are comfortable with disharmonious relationships you avoid working on, unfulfilling and unhealthy behaviour patterns, anxiety, intrusive thoughts, resentments, pain from the past, beliefs about yourself and the world that limit you *greatly*.

It's about keeping the status quo and I'm wondering if it is really all that comfortable. What is the force behind it? Fear.

It's All About Fear

If you have a comfort zone, you must also have a discomfort zone. And what's out there in the discomfort zone? All those experiences you are afraid of. Consider these:

- Emotions you have been avoiding;
- Changes that seem risky;
- Healing from trauma and wounding;
- Potential and possibility that you aren't allowing yourself to see;
- The unknown, outside of what you believe to be true;
- Ease with whatever life brings you;
- The freshness of life unfolding as it is.

Living in your comfort zone divides the whole of reality into areas that are acceptable and unacceptable. It is a mind-created, fear-based division that requires you to manage your life experiences so you don't stray into unfamiliar territory.

Although you stay 'safe,' you draw imaginary lines in the totality of what is possible that keep you stuck, scared, and dissatisfied. Feeling worthless, small, or doubtful, spinning your wheels in old baggage, thinking of yourself as a victim, habits that don't serve—these are the province of the comfort zone.

The comfort zone may be safe, but what does it deny? Enthusiasm, wonder, curiosity, and infinite possibility beyond the mind's limits pertaining to life and relationships. Is it really that great?

An easy way to examine your level of emotional maturity/how much resistance you have to growth is how often you step outside of your comfort zone. If it's rare to put yourself into the vulnerable position of not knowing the answers or how things will turn out, then you likely have trauma/wounding from your past and/or schemas that is holding you hostage—emotionally—and stopping you from fully developing your potential as a person.

'Healing' and living a life from a healed framework is a *very* new experience for a traumatised or wounded person. A life from a healed framework is outside of everything of their subjective life experience and many haven't experienced it since their very early childhood. When I describe this concept in speaking to clients, I use the metaphor of a colour they have never seen:

"Your healthy future is a fantastic colour you have never seen before that I can see, but right now, you can't. How can you perceive it if you've never seen this beautiful colour before? Your current self can't; your past experiences and their effects on your current thoughts, words, actions and behaviours prevent you from seeing it until we clear the past and heal."

Research shows that the older people get, generally, the less open they are to having new experiences. I honestly believe, there will never be a 'right-time' in the future that is 'better' than right now—to even think this is sign of **resistance**. And the more you grow older, the less inclined you will be to want it. And undoubtedly, the level unhappiness you have with your life will fester and grow.

I think the 'comfort zone' should be renamed to the 'the resistance zone.'

Resistance and Working Through It

Before we explore where resistance comes from and how to work with it, it's important to have some clarity on what resistance is

As you step outside of your comfort zone, you will experience the stress-response aka 'resistance' in the form of fight, fly or freeze. Being out of the comfort zone is a beautiful experience because it is entirely physical and emotional. It's a full-on sensory experience—something many people stop experiencing as they grow older.

The main reason this “somatic” (relating to the body, especially as distinct from the mind) experience arises is that when you're out of your “comfort zone”—or in a new situation where you don't fully know how things will turn out—you're in a state of **uncertainty**.

Many psychologists argue: 'uncertainty' is the foundation of all fears. This makes complete sense because our brains are actually designed to predict the outcomes of our behaviour.

Therefore, when we're in a new situation, especially where we aim to heal, all sorts of physical and emotional red lights start to signal—our stress response. What our brain is telling us is that we're in uncharted territory.

It is your relationship with your stress response while dealing with new things and opportunities to heal—that reflects your level of emotional maturity.

You can only change and heal from the effects of the past if you don't give into what the fear/resistance is telling you to do (i.e., hold onto your self-limiting beliefs). You have to make the conscious decision to heal in spite of the resistance you feel towards it. You have to step outside of the false comfort zone and choose healing.

Undoubtedly, the act of stepping outside of your comfort zone and trying something new may trigger negative emotions and memories from the past, but you have learned now that this is natural and something to not be afraid of—**there is no downside of healing from your past, but your brain will do everything it can to make you feel and believe otherwise.**

You've heard the phrase, “What we resist persists.” This is true because **resistance is a form of unhealthy free will that blocks healing.**

Resistance is free will saying, “No, it doesn't feel safe to move forward yet.”

Your resistance is stopping you, in the effort of protecting you, from being FREE of self-limiting beliefs, what has traumatised you or wounded you.

When resistance arises when faced with an opportunity to heal from its important to acknowledge, honour and work with it until it's paralysing grip is loosened. Ultimately, the goal is to get all aspects your conscious and unconscious intentions, working together.

Resistance is showing up because whatever you're trying to do (wanting to heal, move in a new direction, let go of an old story, etc.) doesn't feel safe yet.

Realise that staying in the comfort zone takes effort and vigilance. It resists what is. It hides from what is true. **It makes you believe, via how you identify, that you are fraction of who you really are.**

It actually takes more effort and energy to stay in your comfort zone than to heal from it—you will, unfortunately, only truly realise this statement once you have healed and look back on your past from a healed framework.

Step away from playing it safe, you'll enter the world of possibility. When you do, you stop basing your life on what is false and instead live the actual truth. So rather than push resistance away, invite it closer.

Quick Exercise - Take a Moment and Do This:

Connect with your heart and see what you really want. I doubt you're truly comfortable playing it safe. Take a moment to find out what it's trying to protect you from by talking with it. Begin by being with the resistance and say,

"I see you... (pausing to "see" it)"

"I hear you... (pausing to listen to it)"

Now, say to it *"I honour you and thank you for trying to protect me. I honour what you are trying to tell me, let's build new and important layers of trust so I can be free of what you are wanting to protect me from."*

Visualise the resistance. Visualise putting the feeling of resistance into a box that is outside of your thoughts/mind, heart and body. As you visualise, make the box smaller and smaller until it disappears. **DO THE VISUALISATION.**

You can do it. You can heal. This is how confidence, emotional maturity and strength of character is developed. It starts with understanding and acknowledging resistance, followed by a shift in your attitude and being courageous.

Attitude and Courage

In life, I believe attitude is *everything*, especially when it comes to being a victim or a creator, coupled with the courage to step into the unknown. The circumstances and events that have shaped our lives are as unique and individual as our personalities—no two are the same and many experiences that traumatised and wounded us were out of our control. Yet our ability to grow as individuals, to evolve into more conscious people that take real control in creating a positive future, depends not on what has happened to us, but on our *attitude and courage* toward healing from these experiences.

When faced with trauma and wounding, do you lie down or step up?

Do you resist and allow the trauma and wounding to shape thoughts, words, and actions, or be courageous—embracing healing and growth?

The answer to these questions starts with your *attitude* coupled with courage.

Choose Your Attitude: Are You A Victim Or Are You A Creator?

The attitude you develop over the course of your life can be as important as the experiences you gather during your life. Do you see yourself as a victim or are you empowered with a healthy attitude and are a creator?

Are you in charge of your life and able to heal?

The answer is YES—even if you ‘feel’ it isn’t... Lets explore what can be done about it.

What Can Be Done About All Of This?

While reactions to trauma, wounding and schemas can vary widely, and not everyone will develop Post-Traumatic Stress Disorder (PTSD) or have beliefs systems, emotions and behaviours automatically effected, they can change the brain in some predictable ways that everyone should be aware of. Especially if you or someone close to you is struggling.

Starting with increased awareness of your reality and resistance, you can seek treatment to fully address your symptoms, issues, belief symptoms and all associated negative/unhealthy effects.

Additionally, knowing what's going on can be immensely helpful because it may help you realise that you're not crazy, irreversibly damaged, or a bad person. Instead, you can think of a traumatised/wounded brain/heart and person as one that functions differently as a result of traumatic or wounding events. **It's important to note, just as your brain changed in response to your past experiences with the world, it can also change in response to your future experiences.** In other words, the brain is "plastic," and you can change it. **You can heal.**

You, the person reading this, have survived your entire life up until this very moment and that is amazing in itself. You are still here through all the heartbreak, the hurt, the anger, the sadness, the loss, the pain, the devastation, the anguish and the suffering.

But...

Be brutally honest with yourself.

Are you operating life with coping strategies that essentially shut down possibility in an area or multiple areas of your life? Or are you *truly* free from your past and have real choice in what you create moving forward from this very moment?

Answer these questions honestly because the rest of your life could depend on it.

You may be thinking to yourself, "Easier said than done", and I get it. From working with clients and with my own traumatic, wounding and schemas, I understand that it sucks, a lot. It and the resistance feels hard. You don't want to let go 'cos its part of 'who you are'.

You now understand that there are three mechanisms in your brain that are doing everything that they can to keep you in this 'victim narrative' and direct you away from true healing with coping strategies—both adaptive and maladaptive. But, in short, a

lot can be done and it's okay—we are not born with the knowledge or skills to truly heal from our past, nor are we born with the ability to stop everything that traumatises and wounds us before they happen. I didn't know it was possible until I pushed back against how my brain was affecting me via resistance and experienced it myself. I'm here to invite you to do the same by shifting your attitude right now and seek the help you need.

What is the best time to seek help?

Hint: it's not when you feel ready because that won't happen in time for you to take meaningful action. The best time is right now!

My Invite To You — The Clean Slate Process™ (TCSP™)

I, the founder of TCSP™, invite you to shift your attitude right now, to be courageous in the face of fear, resistance, and start the healing journey. I have been practising my own highly developed form of rapid change/schema/trauma therapy that I call The Clean Slate Process™ with consistent, amazing results for over 5 years. I invite you to work with me to be truly free.

We get to a point in our lives where we cannot blame our parents anymore. We can't blame our ex's, or bosses, anyone or anything.

Is that point right now?

If it's not right now, what is stopping you from making this point

now? Is it your trauma, wounding or schemas?

Is it fear of the

unknown? Is it

resistance?

And, the big question:

What is the downside of letting go of fear? (Hint, there is no downside!)

TCSP™ is the culmination of over 15 years of practise and study of personal development and the science of lasting, rapid change and healing. It's my life's work. Initially, I tried and was unable to deal with my issues via the traditional, mainstream therapies such as Cognitive Behaviour Therapy. These therapies do work for some, but they didn't work for me. Why? I don't exactly know. Experiencing the shift and tools I was yearning for all started when, at the hands of a rapid change practitioner, I experienced instant and lasting change to an issue I was dealing with that I was unable to resolve and heal from in any traditional form of therapy. From there, I delved headfirst into the world of learning rapid change therapy and associated modalities to create The Clean Slate Process™. I'm a giver and passionate about helping people and creating lasting transformational change. I spend countless hours constantly adding to my understanding of psychology, rapid change technologies, emotions, human behaviour, sexuality, and relationships. Yes, I'm clearly obsessed!

With constant development, TCSP™ is based on combining a whole bunch of effective rapid change technologies and refining them to be the most highly effective techniques that they can be. It provides you with a 'Clean Slate' across the board — psychologically, emotionally, energetically and for many clients, physically.

TCSP™ is an elegantly simple, yet comprehensive, rapid change system which resolves trauma/wounding and related issues (for a full list, see below).

The systems is designed for individuals of couples. Within the realm of helping couples, I treat each person in the relationship as individuals and I've found that once you 'clean up' the individuals, that the relationship improves dramatically. Why? Its because the most common relationship issues stem from the intersection of the unhealthy and negative effects of trauma and schema that each individual within the relationship faces.

TCSP™ has achieved results quickly, effectively and safely. The vast majority of clients have had their issues resolved with just 1-2 sessions. The session could be a couple of hours or longer and its duration is based on your unique set of circumstances — there is no one size fits all approach with my TCSP™.

TCSP™ gets to the bottom of your unhappiness and can truly be the catalyst for creating the life you want and allows you to 'free'. Together we discover, heal and release the trauma, schemas and theirs effects, that in turn, caused you to download a particular program that continues to play out as patterns and reactions that really don't serve you.

It is a truly eclectic therapy. It has a structure based on a lot research and testing prior to it being offered to the public. It's still dynamic in its application as each session and processes used are unique—tailored to exactly what you are going through and wanting to achieve. It includes components of Gestalt, Mindfulness, Shamanic Practises, EMDR, Timeline, Schema Therapy and many others. Everything is pulled in to create a holistic, non-diagnostic therapy session that is perfect for you at this time.

Non-diagnostic therapy is a way of constructing therapy that does not follow the traditional method of first diagnosing and then engaging in a prescribed treatment approach based on that diagnosis (i.e., the [DSM-IV](#) - Diagnostic and Statistical Manual of Mental

Disorders and related "standards of practice"). Instead, I relate to you holistically, understanding that suffering, while serious and painful, need not be understood only in prescribed ways. Further, I relate to you as someone unique, and therefore do not

assume that one can make decisions about how to help you who is suffering based solely on a category or categories of suffering (i.e., diagnosis).

TCSP™ is a dynamic, rich and sequenced series of steps based on your unique set of circumstances, which, if separated would not be anywhere near as powerful. It focuses on healing and change—allowing space for your needs to be met.

TCSP™ makes use of *some* conversational hypnosis. Conversational hypnosis is used in order to initially access and deal with trauma and wounding where it is stored—in the subconscious and in the body. (Levine, van der Kolk, Rothschild, Ogden.)

During Hypnosis, you are still conscious of what I'm saying and your surroundings. Unlike stage hypnosis, you will be able to remember everything about the hypnotic component of TCSP™. You can read more detail about the differences between stage hypnosis and therapeutic hypnosis [here](#). If you are still uneasy about it after speaking directly with me, I invite to bring a friend with you that you trust knowing about your issues, to witness this part of the process. I allow this to ensure you are confident that you are being treated in a safe and ethical manner.

TCSP™ is in alignment with the two requirements stated by Van Der Kolk, Levine and other trauma experts.

For trauma to be resolved:

- the person must (somehow) be moved to an empowered (resolved) position in regard to the trauma and wounding
- the body must (somehow) know that the event / events are over

TCSP™ initially deals with the underlying, unconscious core beliefs which keep a person stuck in patterns of thought, emotion and behaviour. In dealing with this at the beginning of the process, self-sabotage is avoided during the rest of your session.

TCSP™ does not merely address the symptoms of trauma. It deals with the underlying cause of the problem by discharging the emotional charge from the past held by the amygdala, moving you to a place of empowerment and resolution in relation to the past.

Because hypnosis is used in combination with my highly developed trauma/schema clearing process, I can then speak directly to the body and to the unconscious. You are shifted from trauma response, fight-flight-freeze and victim narrative and moved to a self-regulated, empowered creator state. The sympathetic nervous system is calmed.

The memory and effects of the trauma is placed firmly in the past.

Your entire neurophysiology and brain are quickly moved from the state of 'I'm not safe!' to 'Its over. I'm safe now...' Calm and clarity returns, on all levels. Symptoms cease.

Towards the end of the session, I supercharge your psyche/future self with a new and healthy framework that is specifically designed based on your unique personality and goals.

I then periodically check in with you to see how you are progressing and if needed, fine tweak your framework. In my experience, approximately only 1 out of every 20 people have needed a quick tune-up after the first session and if needed, will be **free of charge**.

Applications of TCSP™ Beyond Trauma and Wounding:

In the *vast* majority of cases, TCSP™ has also successfully resolved the following issues:

- All fears & phobias, including public speaking, heights, confined areas, spiders, snakes, judgment and more
- Psychological trauma
- Reduce and even eliminate all PTSD symptoms and associated beliefs
- Sexual trauma (abuse, sexual assault etc.) and other sex related issues
- Self-limiting beliefs and maladaptive behavioral/coping strategies
- Emotional and verbal abuse
- Physical abuse (can include punching, hitting, slapping, kicking, strangling, or physically restraining a partner against their will. It can also include driving recklessly or invading someone's physical space, and in any other way making someone feel physically unsafe)
- Relationship breakdown and 'getting over an ex'
- Effects of being gas lighted. (Gas lighting means to manipulate someone by psychological means into doubting their own memory, perception, and sanity)
- Intrusive thoughts
- Abuse from a narcissist (a form of emotional abuse projected by a narcissist on to another individual. Although narcissistic abuse is primarily focused on emotional and psychological abuse, there are other types of narcissistic abuse

No part of this book may be reproduced or published in any form or by any means, without permission in writing from the author. Contact shae@shaemattthews.com for more information

(c) 2023 - TCSP™ Healing & Rapid Change Foundation

that can be classified in this category. These include abuses such as financial, spiritual, sexual, and physical. Read in detail [here](#))

- Anxiety (general or specific)
- Body image issues
- Confidence issues
- Fear of success
- Anger, resentment, frustration, unable to forgive
- Self-confidence issues, insecurities, feeling not good enough
- Addictions, alcohol, gambling, sugar, cyber-porn, comfort eating, binge eating etc
- Feeling stuck and uncertain of direction, lack of motivation
- Negative emotions
- Grief from loss of loved ones
- Nervousness in dating
- Depression
- and much more

Free 30 Minute Consultation with Me

I invite you to take advantage of a free 30 minute consultation (Online/phone or in person) where I can assess if the TCSP™ is right for you, and if so, what your session will entail. You can ask questions and get a feeling for me and the way I work. We'll explore together what has led you to this point in life, and more importantly, how it plays out in your present and what it may mean for your future. The TCSP™ can be delivered in person or via Skype.

To learn more and organise your free 30 minute consultation, email shae@shaemattthews.com and I will get back to you or visit www.shaemattthews.com and make a booking..

After speaking with me via a free consultation, I invite you to speak with people who have gone through the process before—they are more than willing to share their experiences of TCSP™ and their life after it. Give yourself this gift of healing, you deserve it and to be free of all your past.

My Final Words:

I truly hope you got something from reading my book and learning about my process that radically transforms lives for the better. You may want to read it again to help to process the information and feel free to share this with your friends or family that may benefit from it.

No part of this book may be reproduced or published in any form or by any means, without permission in writing from the author. Contact shae@shaemattthews.com for more information
(c) 2023 - TCSP™ Healing & Rapid Change Foundation

If you resonate with anything that has been highlighted in this writing, then I hope it has helped you understand more about yourself and/or others close to you. More importantly, I hope it's filled you with hope that you can heal. It's very important to understand that knowing all of this is just the start of healing it, so what action you take from this point and any lack of action will affect your future.

TESTIMONIALS

TESTIMONIALS

Transformative Journeys with Shae Matthews - Real Stories of Change

Andrew - 37, IT Specialist: Breaking Free from a Tormented Past

'My world was blocked by so much baggage from my horrible past... Shae changed my life in ways that surpassed my expectations. The healing and changes I went through are more than just now being able to be sexually open with my partner though... My life has improved in every way and I cannot thank him enough...'

Matthew - 33, Freelance Writer: Triumph Over Deep-Seated Trauma

'My biggest challenge was that I didn't believe that anything would work considering I had so much trauma... Shae is my angel, when I had absolutely no faith in men he restored my life, my faith, and my beliefs in just one afternoon... The negativity has lifted from myself and I'm a free man...'

James - 45, Business Owner: A Marriage Rekindled with Newfound Happiness

'Our marriage really struggled... I came across Shae... The next day I could feel I was happy and positive and had energy... When I came home it was like my wife and I could see clearly again... Our marriage through The Clean Slate Process was transformed and we are so happy together again...'

'Our marriage started out with lots of laughs and happiness. Then came the kids and for the next 15 years our marriage really struggled. We both wanted to be happy but didn't know how. We knew we both loved each other but found it impossible to reconnect on a deep positive level. We tried traditional couples counselling but grew sick of repeating our heartache to countless strangers who seemed clueless as to what we really needed. Out of desperation, I kept looking for a solution. I came across Shae via a mutual friend and after a brief chat, he sent me his short e-book on the topic. Once I read it I knew he was onto something. I quickly shared it with my wife who by this stage was a real skeptic. She read it cover to cover five times before telling me to book him in. A few days later I spent a full day in session with Shae and came home buzzing. The next day I could feel I was happy and positive and had energy. I felt like was a completely new person. So transformational was the change I knew I also needed to see Shae. A couple of days later I went for my marathon clean slate session. It was like nothing else I had ever done. It was confronting and liberating. It made me face my fears and insecurities while being supported and truly understood.'

It gave me the confidence to power back into life again. With that weight lifted I looked at the world in a whole new light. When I came home it was like my wife and I could see clearly again. She looks beautiful again and I'm falling in love with her all over again. Our marriage through The Clean Slate Process was transformed and we are so happy together again. I can't thank Shae enough for such a wonderful gift.'

Richard - 54, Architect: From Rock Bottom to Unprecedented Heights

'Before attending my Clean Slate session with Shae, my life was at rock bottom... He made me confront, deal with and release the traumas that were holding me back... Now, I feel like a weight has been removed from my shoulders... If you are sitting on the fence about going ahead with a Clean Slate session, I strongly suggest you give it a try...'

'I don't normally give testimonials, however, the transformation Shae made in my personal life was so life-changing I feel the need to share it with others. Before attending my Clean Slate session with Shae, my life was at rock bottom. My 19-year marriage with the love of my life and my personal life was at an all-time low. We were about to walk away from one another. I had given my marriage 6 months before an ultimatum was given. I was unhappy with my personal life and growth. Many traumas and misconceptions were swirling around in my mind creating an uncertain and unhappy person. I felt lost. I felt helpless. I felt desperate.

I had been to many psychologists and counsellors over the years but always felt like I was just going back every month for appointments with no real change. It was so frustrating. I didn't want to stay living like this. Meeting Shae has been the biggest blessing of my life. He has changed me in so many ways and I am forever indebted to him.

His specialized unorthodox approach is exactly what I needed. It was what I was searching for—actual change and growth. He made me confront, deal with and release the traumas that were holding me back from being the person I knew I could be. Now, I feel like a weight has been removed from my shoulders. The past hurts are always going to be a part of who you are, as they are what shape you, however, my past no longer controls and dominates my mind and my life. I walked away from my day with Shae a whole new person—ready to take on the world. The closeness, intimacy and love in my marriage has been the best it has ever been. We now communicate really well with one another, love on each other even more and having fun again. I can safely say that my marriage is now stronger than it has ever been in the 19 years that we have been together. If you are sitting on the fence about going ahead with a Clean Slate session, I strongly suggest you give it a try. It may be the best thing you ever did, because for me, it has been life-changing.'

David - 40, Corporate Executive: A New Chapter of Harmony and Achievement

'Before my transformative journey with Shae, I was a prisoner to my own success... He guided me through an introspective journey... Now, I look back and hardly recognize the man I was... My relationships are stronger, and every day is a testament to the life-changing magic of Shae's coaching...'

"I'm not one to publicly share my experiences, but the profound impact of Shae Matthews on my life compels me to break my silence. Before my transformative journey with Shae, I was a prisoner to my own success, caught in an endless cycle of overachievement and stress. My professional accolades were many, yet my personal fulfillment was nonexistent. I felt detached, burnt out, and ironically, a perpetual underachiever in my own eyes. It was a life of silent despair.

I had sought help from various professionals, but it was the same cycle of temporary relief without any real, lasting change. Then, I found Shae Matthews. His approach was different, focusing on the root of my 'Unrelenting Standards' schema. He guided me through an introspective journey, challenging my ingrained patterns and helping me establish a new paradigm of living.

Now, I look back and hardly recognize the man I was. The weight of constant pressure has lifted, and in its place is a sense of peace and genuine happiness. I've reconnected with loved ones, found joy in leisure, and my career is thriving in a healthier way. My relationships are stronger, and every day is a testament to the life-changing magic of Shae's coaching. To those on the fence, take that leap of faith. It might just be the most rewarding journey you'll ever embark on."

Ethan - 28, Graphic Designer: From Isolation to Connection

'My life was a series of walls I built around myself... Everything changed when I met Shae Matthews... Today, I live a life enriched with meaningful relationships and a strong sense of self-worth... Shae's coaching isn't just therapy; it's a journey to the heart of who you are...'

"Writing this testimonial feels surreal because, for the longest time, I believed I'd always be the outsider, the one perpetually looking in. My life was a series of walls I built around myself, stemming from a deep-rooted sense of 'Social Isolation' and 'Defectiveness.' I moved through life feeling invisible and disconnected, fearing rejection at every turn. My attempts at therapy always felt like I was just going through the motions without any real understanding or progress.

Everything changed when I met Shae Matthews. His coaching wasn't just a band-aid solution but a deep dive into the core of my issues. He provided a space where I felt seen and understood, something I'd been craving for so long. Shae's patient and insightful approach helped me dismantle the barriers I had erected over the years.

Today, I live a life enriched with meaningful relationships and a strong sense of self-worth. I no longer view the world through a lens of fear but one of hope and possibility. I've found my tribe, and more importantly, I've found myself. Shae's coaching isn't just therapy; it's a journey to the heart of who you are. If you're yearning for real change, Shae is the guide you need."

Marcus - 55, Engineer: Rebuilding Foundations of Trust and Love

'My life, particularly my family life, was under the shadow of a deep-seated 'Abandonment' schema... Then, I encountered Shae Matthews... Now, my family bonds are stronger than ever... For anyone who feels trapped by their past, Shae offers a path to freedom and a future filled with potential and love.'

"I've never been one to expose my vulnerabilities, but the transformation I've undergone compels me to share my story. My life, particularly my family life, was under the shadow of a deep-seated 'Abandonment' schema. This fear manifested in ways that strained the very relationships I cherished the most. I was overbearing, mistrustful, and inadvertently pushing my loved ones away. Despite various attempts at therapy, I remained shackled by my past, unable to move forward.

Then, I encountered Shae Matthews. His understanding of human psychology and his ability to tailor his approach to my specific needs were unlike anything I'd experienced before. He guided me through a process of understanding, acceptance, and ultimately, transformation. Shae's coaching helped me rebuild the foundations of my relationships on trust, communication, and unconditional love.

Now, my family bonds are stronger than ever. I approach life with a newfound openness and confidence. The change is not just in how I interact with my loved ones but in how I view myself. For anyone who feels trapped by their past, Shae offers a path to freedom and a future filled with potential and love."

Jordan - 32, Marketing Consultant: Rising from the Ashes of Doubt

'I was a man haunted by a 'Failure' schema... When I started working with Shae, it was as if he saw straight into my soul... The person I am today is a testament to Shae's profound impact... If you're at a crossroads, feeling defeated by your fears, Shae Matthews is the beacon of hope you've been seeking.'

"I'm sharing my story because what Shae Matthews has done for me is nothing short of a rebirth. I was a man haunted by a 'Failure' schema, constantly feeling like an impostor in my own life. Despite outward successes, I was crumbling under the weight of self-doubt and fear of exposure. I tried different therapists and coaches, but nothing seemed to address the core of my insecurities.

When I started working with Shae, it was as if he saw straight into my soul. His coaching was a blend of empathy, wisdom, and practical strategies that targeted the very essence of my fears. He provided me with the tools to reconstruct my self-image, transforming my fear of failure into a stepping stone for growth and resilience.

The person I am today is a testament to Shae's profound impact. I take on challenges with courage, embrace my vulnerabilities, and celebrate my victories, big and small. My personal and professional lives are flourishing, and it's all thanks to the journey I embarked on with Shae. If you're at a crossroads, feeling defeated by your fears, Shae Matthews is the beacon of hope you've been seeking."

Couples Therapy Testimonial - Richard and Jasmin - Married 19 years.

"My biggest challenge was that I didn't believe that anything would work considering I had so much trauma, It seemed so out of reach to lead a trauma-free life that I actually didn't believe that anything would work. Initially, I thought if it sounded too good to be true it probably was, but, I knew I had to try something. My issues and past trauma made me feel trapped and all up in my head, like I had no hope at all, I was heavy in my head, heavy in my heart and I was constantly physically sick. The big day came and I was nervous, scared, and excited, my session was 6 hrs long and to be honest it has been the best thing I have ever done in my life, I now lead a trauma-free, exciting life and I'm actually physically healing, Shae is my angel, when I had absolutely no faith in men he restored my life, my faith, and my beliefs in just one afternoon. I trust this man and for me to say this is unbelievable, he is absolute magic. The whole time I was there I felt safe cause he had me in his wings, I was safe, secure, extremely vulnerable and he just held me in complete safety. He understood me better than I understood myself. I do not emotionally eat anymore and I have lost a dress size, After suffering from domestic violence for 15 years I can actually have someone be physically intimate with me without fear. I'm setting boundaries I never knew I could and I choose how I live my life, Shae has given me the tools to get over any trauma and anything that comes my way. I absolutely adore him and I think he is an angel. The negativity has lifted from myself and I'm a free man. The only person you are going to lose is the traumatized self what you are gaining is your true strong self JUST DO IT live your life the right way. After what I experienced, I honestly believe what Shae has developed is fail-proof and I believe in his work. I happily recommend him to anyone willing and wanting to heal and lead an amazing life'

TCSP™ IN PRACTISE - DETAILED CASE STUDY: ALICE

Name: Alex

Age: 27

Gender Identification: Male Sexual Orientation: Heterosexual

TCSP™ Date: July 2019

Issues:

Alex was deeply affected by repeated instances of bullying and emotional abuse during his teenage years and early adulthood. These experiences significantly impacted his mental well-being, leading to persistent anxiety, self-doubt, and a deep-seated mistrust of others, particularly authority figures. He struggled with addictive behaviors, particularly excessive drinking and gaming, as a form of escapism. His thoughts often circled around failure and inadequacy, intensifying during periods of stress and isolation.

Prior to the TCSP™, alongside detailed history taking and various assessments via psychometric testing and schema testing, Alex was asked to give each one of these issues and his symptoms a subjective rating (out of ten). He was asked to note how often and how severe these thoughts and feelings were over the 4 weeks prior to the TCSP™. This, along with the results of the psychometric testing, served as a baseline for the severity of his symptoms, issues, and to measure the success of the TCSP™.

Self-Reported Symptoms, Challenges, and Self-Limiting Beliefs:

- Anxiety and a general distrust of others, particularly in professional and social settings.
- Feelings of inadequacy and failure, especially in his career and personal achievements.
- An aversion to forming close relationships due to fear of betrayal or being judged.
- Feeling stuck and unable to progress in his career and personal life. 'I feel like I'm constantly hitting a wall.'
- Difficulty in asserting himself and expressing his needs and boundaries.

- Chronic stress which began after persistent bullying in his teenage years.
- Feelings of prolonged frustration, anger, loneliness, and a lack of motivation and enjoyment in life.
- Resorting to alcohol and gaming as a means to cope with stress and loneliness.
- Self-destructive thoughts and behaviors, including excessive drinking and neglecting his health.

Goals of treatment:

- Empower him to build trust and form meaningful relationships free of anxiety and fear
- Reconnect him with his sense of self-worth and confidence
- Enable him to break through personal and professional barriers with optimism
- Eradicate his chronic stress and instill a sense of peace and stability
- Manage the overwhelming nature of his emotions and intrusive thoughts
- Eliminate all thoughts and behaviors related to self-destructive habits
- Motivate him to adopt healthier coping mechanisms and practices

Success of TCSP™

The TCSP™ has successfully achieved Alex's stated goals for his treatment.

The severity of all his symptoms and associated feelings decreased dramatically to 0 out of 10.

His words in response to the unhealthy emotions, anxiety, thoughts, etc., after experiencing TCSP™ were 'that's completely gone,' 'I don't feel held back anymore,' 'I can look back at my past struggles without feeling weighed down by them,' and 'I've found a peace and stability I never thought possible.'

Update:

At the time of writing this ebook and case study, it has been over 1 year since Alex experienced TCSP™.

He reports that all of the changes are still lasting. He has formed strong, trusting relationships and no longer feels governed by fear or inadequacy. He asserts his needs confidently and has taken proactive steps in his career. He has left his self-destructive habits behind and has embraced healthier ways of coping with stress. He is optimistic about his future and rarely, if ever, finds himself ruminating over his past struggles. When past issues do come to mind, they no longer cause him emotional distress.

He continues to practice healthier habits and has found no need to seek further psychological help since completing TCSP™.

DISCLAIMER: TCSP™ is not meant to replace any professional mental health therapy such as psychology, psychiatry, or any other therapy that you are currently undergoing, nor is it meant to help you come off/cease any medication that is prescribed to you by a mental health professional. It is illegal for me, or any practitioner of TCSP™, to advise you to stop working with any mental health professional(s) and/or to stop taking prescribed medication, now or in the future. You WILL NOT get this type of advice or recommendation by me or any other practitioner of TCSP™. The above is just what this client has reported and in no way did I advise him to stop seeing his psychologist.

Thank you for your time in reading my e-book - I know it's a lot to take in.

If you would like me to be a part of your healing journey, email shae@shaemattthews.com or book a call directly shaemattthews.com and I will get back to you. It will be my honor to help you heal and lay the formations of an amazing future.